



Separate Nightmares

when ocean meets sky

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CHAPTER 1

Dust-Blanked Gate to Kai's Wasteland

Kai woke with one hand pressed into heat.

Not warmth. Heat - hard and immediate, rising through his palm as if the ground had a furnace beneath its cracked grey-yellow skin. The bones of his fingers had gone numb. When he tried to pull away, the earth held him for half a second too long.

Then it let go.

Kai lurched upright. The sky above him was the color of old ash, without sun or cloud, yet the light burned against his eyes. A thin line of darkness stretched from his heels across the plain. It trembled independently of him.

His shadow was being dragged.

"No," Kai whispered.

The word fell flat. The wasteland swallowed the sound before it traveled.

He looked for Sora. There was no movement anywhere, no cry, no footprint except the shallow impressions his body had made in the dust. The silence pressed against his ears until he could hear the small wet click of his own swallowing.

Sora had to be somewhere beyond the heat.

Kai forced himself to stand. His knees buckled, but he caught himself against a slab of bone protruding from the ground. It was pale beneath the dust, too large

to belong to any animal he knew. A rib, perhaps. Or the curved remains of something that had once carried a body far bigger than his.

His first thought was simple: find a way forward.

His second was that forward had already disappeared.

The horizon circled him. He knew that was impossible. He knew the jagged ridge to his left had been behind him a moment ago, because he had seen its broken teeth when he woke. Now it stood ahead, low and distant, while the skeletal remains had shifted to his right.

Kai wiped grit from his eyes. His fingers came away streaked with grey.

"Move," he told himself.

The shadow jerked.

Pain opened along his spine. Kai dropped to one knee as the darkness behind him stretched thin, pulled toward a point beneath the earth. His body leaned with it. For one sickening instant he felt himself dividing - not flesh from flesh, but weight from weight, the part of him that occupied the world peeling away from the part that remembered how.

He slammed both hands into the dirt.

The heat climbed through his wrists.

Something clicked nearby.

Kai turned.

A white mask lay half-buried a few feet away. It had no features except shallow hollows where eyes might have been and a narrow split for a mouth. Dust had collected inside it. The surface was cracked from brow to chin.

He stared at it.

The mask stared back.

Not with eyes. With attention.

Kai crawled toward it, keeping his body low. Every movement made the ground shimmer. The air above the dust bent in thin vertical waves, and through them the plain seemed to rearrange itself. A mound became a hollow. A distant stone appeared close enough to touch, then slid away.

The mask's mouth opened.

Kai heard his own voice.

"Find a way forward."

He froze.

The mask repeated him, but the words arrived with a delay, stretched and hollow.

"Find a way forward."

Kai reached for it. His fingertips hovered above the white surface.

"Where is Sora?" he asked.

The mouth opened wider.

"Where is Sora?"

The answer should have comforted him. Instead, the question came back carrying something he had not said aloud.

Where did you leave her?

Kai snatched his hand away.

The mask tilted in the dust.

A tremor passed beneath the ground. The fissures around it widened, black and narrow. They did not spread randomly. They bent toward his feet, then away, forming angles that suggested a route before twisting into a shape like a hooked finger.

Kai rose too quickly. The world lurched sideways.

His left ear filled with a high metallic whine. His right heard nothing at all. He slapped the side of his head and shouted, but the wasteland gave him no echo. His voice had become a movement in his throat, visible only in the vibration of his fingers.

The shadow pulled again.

This time, it took something.

Kai felt a strip of cold leave his back. His skin remained, but the sensation of skin did not. He could see his shirt pressed against his shoulders, yet the cloth no longer touched him. His body was becoming an outline of itself.

He staggered away from the mask.

The dust ahead bulged.

At first Kai thought the ground had collapsed. Then a hand pushed through. It was pale, jointed wrong, and covered in the same grey grit as the plain. A second hand followed. The thing pulled itself free without making a sound.

It had no head that Kai could see. Its upper body was a knot of damp flesh, folded around a vertical mouth. The mouth opened and closed, tasting the air.

Kai backed toward the ribs.

The creature answered the mask.

"Forward," it said.

Its voice came from beneath the ground, from inside Kai's teeth, from the hollow between one thought and the next.

Kai grabbed a broken length of bone. The heat had made it slick. He raised it with both hands.

"Stay away."

The creature unfolded another limb. It was not an arm. It had too many elbows, each one bending as if searching for the correct direction.

Kai swung.

The bone struck the thing's side and sank halfway in. There was no impact, only resistance like wet cloth. The creature folded around the weapon.

Kai let go.

The mask began laughing with his voice.

He ran.

The plain offered no straight line. Each step carried him toward a different horizon. His boots struck hard ground, then loose grit, then a surface that flexed beneath him like buried muscle. He stumbled past scattered masks - white, grey, some blackened at the edges. Their mouths opened as he passed.

"Left."

"Right."

"Behind."

"Sora."

The voices overlapped until they became a single rasping command.

Kai chose the ridge.

It shifted away.

He ran harder. Heat crawled up his legs. His calves vanished beneath his own gaze, not disappearing entirely but losing their boundaries, the edges dissolving into wavering dust. He could still move them. He could still feel the effort in the muscles, though the feeling arrived from somewhere beside him.

A fissure snapped shut behind his heel.

Kai fell forward and struck the ground with his shoulder. His arm went numb from elbow to fingertips. He rolled onto his back and saw the sky spinning without motion, a fixed grey vault turning inside his skull.

The creature was coming.

He could not hear it, but dust rose in a line across the plain. Masks shifted as it passed. One cracked open beneath its weight, revealing darkness where a face should have been.

Kai pushed himself upright.

The skeletal remains stood ahead.

They had not moved. He understood that now. The landscape had moved around them, hiding and revealing the landmark like a hand covering an eye. The ribs rose from the earth in a crooked arch, and beneath them lay a half-buried skull, its jaw split open.

A shelter. A marker. Anything.

Kai crawled toward it.

His shadow dragged behind him, stretched so thin it looked painted on the dust. A dark strand ran from its edge toward the creature. Kai reached back and

seized it.

The shadow had texture.

It felt like cold hair soaked in oil.

Something pulled from the other end.

Kai screamed and hauled himself forward. The sound returned in pieces, delayed and broken. He heard the beginning of it from the sky, the middle from the ground, the end whispered by the mask nearest his hand.

"Don't let go."

Kai looked down.

The white mask had followed him.

It lay beside his wrist, clean now, its cracks filled with a faint yellow light. Its mouth moved in time with his breathing.

"Don't let go," it said.

"Shut up."

"Shut up."

"Tell me where Sora is."

The mask's eyes deepened.

"She is already - "

Kai drove his fist through it.

The shell broke with a sharp, dry snap. Fragments cut his knuckles. Beneath the white surface there was no hollow interior, only a warm darkness that pulsed once against his skin.

The instant it broke, every mask on the plain turned toward him.

Kai felt the turn rather than saw it. Pressure gathered along his face, his throat, the back of his eyes. Hundreds of empty features fixed on him.

The creature stopped.

For the first time, it made a sound.

It was Sora's voice.

"Kai."

He nearly answered.

The name came from beneath the ribs, soft and frightened. His body leaned toward it before his mind could intervene.

"Kai, please."

He clamped his teeth together.

The creature repeated her, closer.

"Kai."

He seized the broken mask fragment and pressed its sharp edge into his palm. Pain flashed bright and real. Blood surfaced, dark against the dust.

The voice faltered.

Kai drove the fragment into the ground.

The fissures lit beneath him.

They ran outward in branching lines, crossing and recrossing until a narrow path appeared through the wasteland. It led beneath the skeletal arch. For one moment, every direction agreed.

Kai moved.

The creature lunged.

Its limbs struck the dust behind him, close enough to spray his back with hot grit. Kai threw himself beneath the ribs. The skull's broken jaw hung above him. Its teeth were worn smooth, each one pointing inward.

He crawled into the hollow beneath it and pulled his shadow after him.

The darkness resisted.

Kai wrapped both hands around the thin black strand. It burned cold, a pain that reached past skin and into memory. He pulled until something inside his chest tore loose.

His shadow snapped beneath the skull.

The creature recoiled.

Kai collapsed against the buried bones, gasping. His legs were still there. His hands were still attached. But when he looked down, his body seemed unfinished. The heat had erased the fine certainty of him: the boundary of his wrist, the shape of his knees, the exact place where his skin ended and the dust began.

He had found the landmark.

He had not escaped.

Across the plain, the masks began to move.

One slid into the fissured path. Then another. Then another, arranging themselves nose to mouth in a pale procession that led directly beneath the ribs.

Their empty eyes faced Kai.

The first mask spoke.

"Kai."

He covered his ears.

The second spoke with Sora's voice.

"Kai, look."

He shut his eyes.

Behind his lids, the path brightened. He could see it without sight, feel each mask taking its place. The voices thinned until they were no longer sounds but directions inside his skull.

The landscape had learned where he was.

And now it was teaching him how to follow.

CHAPTER 2

The First Mask That Speaks His Name

Kai stepped where the nearest mask pointed, though it had no finger, no hand, nothing but a narrow split mouth and two shallow hollows turned toward the skeletal arch.

The ground shifted beneath his boot.

A fissure opened with a dry crack, running between the scattered faces. Kai lurched sideways, bone raised in one hand, and caught himself against a rib of the landmark. Heat poured through the pale structure. It smelled of scorched salt and something sweet rotting beneath it.

The masks had been aligned when he reached the arch. Now half of them faced away.

One lay upside down in the dust. Another had rolled several feet from its place, its cracked surface pressed into the grey-yellow earth. The rest formed a crooked trail toward a depression beyond the bones, where the wasteland dipped out of sight.

A route, if the masks meant what the first one had meant.

A safe route, if any word in this place still held its shape.

Kai looked back. His shadow stretched behind him in thin, broken strips, as if invisible hands still worried it apart. He could feel each tug in his calves. The memory of being dragged remained in his body, a pain without a wound.

"Sora," he called.

His voice traveled beneath the arch and came back altered.

"Sora."

The echo sounded close enough to touch.

Kai tightened his grip on the bone. "That wasn't you."

The answer came from the mask at his feet.

"That wasn't you."

He froze.

The face was half-buried, white beneath the dust, featureless except for its hollows and mouth. A crack ran from its brow to its cheek. Faint yellow light shone inside the broken edges.

Kai crouched without taking his eyes from it. The mask's mouth had not moved. Yet the words had come from there, shaped in his own voice.

He wanted the route. He wanted to reach Sora before the wasteland carried her somewhere even he could not follow. The masks had led him to the arch; their alignment was the only direction that had not changed beneath his feet.

He reached down.

The instant his fingers touched the white mask, every face in the dust turned.

Not rolled. Not shifted with the wind.

Turned.

Ceramic scraped over grit in a widening circle. The sound passed through the wasteland like teeth grinding in sleep.

Kai jerked his hand back, but the mask clung to his palm.

His thoughts broke loose.

Sora is alive.

The words sounded beside his ear.

Sora is alive.

He tried to think of nothing. The mask repeated the silence as a thin, wet hiss.

Where are you?

Where are you?

The voice was his, but something trembled beneath it, a second voice trying to fit inside the first.

Kai slammed the mask against the rib bone. It cracked. Pain flashed through his palm as a shard bit into his skin. The mask dropped, split along the old fracture, and its pieces sank into the dust.

For one breath, nothing moved.

Then the ground answered.

Dust bulged between the masks. A pale ridge rose, collapsed, and rose again. Something underneath dragged itself forward, forcing the earth aside with slow, deliberate pressure.

Kai backed away from the arch.

"Stay down," he whispered.

The creature answered from beneath the dust.

"Stay down."

Its voice did not mimic him cleanly. It had too many throats. The syllables emerged wet and stretched, as if spoken through a mouth packed with sand.

The nearest masks began to chatter.

"Stay down."

"Stay down."

"Stay down."

Kai swung the bone at the first face. It shattered, spraying white fragments across his boots. Yellow light leaked from the pieces and vanished into the cracks.

The creature came free.

It was long and low, built from flesh that had forgotten how to become a body. Arms unfolded from its sides, jointed in the wrong places. A shoulder opened where a hip should have been. Its skin was grey, slick with dust, and folded over itself like wet cloth. No head rose above it. Instead, a mouth opened in the center of its torso.

Inside, Kai saw pale teeth arranged in rings.

The creature pulled itself toward him.

The masks cried out.

Not in fear.

In recognition.

"Kai," they said.

His name crossed the wasteland from every direction.

The creature stopped.

Its mouth widened. A dark tongue emerged, thin as a root, and tasted the air.

"Kai Vesper," it said.

The sound struck deeper than the mimicry. It knew the whole name. The creature lifted one of its crooked arms, and a seam split along its palm.

A smear of black-red flesh pressed through.

Kai ran.

He did not follow the mask trail. The faces had turned toward him now, their mouths aimed like open wounds. He sprinted between them, boots slipping on loose grit, the bone clutched against his ribs.

Behind him, the creature scraped forward.

The sound came faster than its body should have allowed. Limbs struck the ground in uneven rhythm. Dust burst around Kai's ankles. Something brushed his shadow, and his left leg buckled.

He drove the bone into the earth and hauled himself upright.

The fissures had changed. The route the masks had shown him was gone, replaced by a web of narrow breaks. Heat rose through them in pulses. The landscape was not guiding him now. It was closing around him.

He saw the depression ahead and made for it.

A mask blocked his path.

Its white surface was clean despite the dust. No crack marked it. Its hollows were deeper than the others, black enough to swallow the yellow glare beneath the ground.

Kai tried to leap over it.

The mask spoke before his boot landed.

"Left."

He twisted in the air and struck the ground hard on his shoulder. The creature's arm swept through the space where he had been. Its fingers slapped against the mask instead.

The face split.

A sharp white flash filled the depression. The creature recoiled, its arm folding inward with a sound like wet branches breaking.

Kai rolled, came up on one knee, and stared at the mask.

"Left?" he said.

"Left."

The voice was not his this time. It sounded older, though age had no meaning in it. The word carried a pressure that made his teeth ache.

The masks around him shifted together.

A path opened to his left.

Kai ran through it.

The creature screamed. The sound tore across the plain and returned from beneath the ground. More dust rose behind him. Shapes moved under the surface, following the same route.

There was more than one.

Kai's breath rasped in his throat. He passed beneath a leaning span of bone and found the depression widening ahead. The masks lined its edges, all facing inward now. Some were whole. Others lay in fragments, yellow light pulsing faintly within their cracks.

At the center stood a shallow basin filled with ash.

The mask in his hand - he had not realized he still held a piece - began to vibrate.

He looked down. A broken mask fragment rested in his palm, no larger than two fingers, its edge sunk into his cut. Faint yellow light moved through it like a trapped ember.

The voice rose from the shard.

"Walk."

Kai stared at the basin. "Where?"

"Walk."

Behind him, the creature struck the bone arch. The landmark shuddered. A rib fell and broke across the trail.

Kai could flee into the basin or turn and fight in the narrowing passage. The bone in his hand was already cracked near the grip. His shadow dragged behind him, stretched toward the thing hunting him.

He stepped into the ash.

Cold climbed through his boot.

The creature crossed beneath the arch.

It filled the passage, folding and unfolding as it came. Its torso-mouth opened. Teeth clicked in their rings. The black-red smear from its palm had lengthened

into a cord, trailing behind it and leaving dark marks on the ground.

The masks whispered Kai's name.

The creature heard them.

It lunged.

Kai pressed the fragment against his bleeding palm.

The yellow light entered his skin.

Every mask in the basin opened its mouth.

A voice rose from them - not one voice, but a layered murmur that seemed to come from a place beyond the hot sky.

"Chosen."

The creature struck the edge of the ash.

The basin erupted.

White faces lifted from the ground around Kai, not floating but rising on thin columns of dust. Their mouths widened. The air twisted. The creature's reaching limbs stretched toward him, then snapped sideways as if caught by invisible hooks.

It screamed again.

Kai fell backward. The fragment burned in his palm. Lines of yellow light ran up his wrist, branching beneath the skin.

"Stop," he gasped.

The masks repeated him.

"Stop."

The creature dragged itself forward, carving trenches through the ash. Its torso-mouth worked around a word.

"Mine."

The masks answered.

"No."

The creature's headless body convulsed. Flesh tore along its back, revealing a hollow filled with black dust. From that hollow, dozens of narrow limbs unfolded and seized the basin's rim.

Kai scrambled toward the far side.

The mask voices followed him.

"Walk."

"Walk."

"Walk."

He climbed out of the ash and reached the depression's opposite slope. Beyond it, the ground dropped into a narrow ravine. The masks had arranged themselves along its edge, creating a descending line into darkness.

A route.

Not safe. Not anymore.

But open.

Kai looked back once.

The creature had broken through the basin. White masks clung to its limbs, their cracks glowing. It tore them away, and each one screamed his name as it

shattered.

The thing turned toward him.

The smear on its palm had vanished.

A black-red mark now burned across Kai's hand, beneath the yellow light.

The creature lowered itself.

Then it came.

Kai descended into the ravine.

Stone closed around him, sharp and warm. He slid down the slope, caught a jutting ledge, and nearly lost the bone. Above, the creature struck the ravine wall. Dust poured over him. Its limbs searched the opening.

The masks along the descent faced him.

Some whispered directions. Some copied his breathing. One repeated Sora's name until the sound became a thin thread pulled through his skull.

Kai pressed his back to the stone.

"Sora," he said.

The mask nearest his knee answered in her voice.

"Kai."

He shut his eyes.

The voice came again, softer.

"Kai, don't follow."

His grip tightened around the bone. It sounded like Sora. It carried the familiar break at the end of his name, the small uncertainty she used when she was afraid but refused to show it.

"Where are you?"

The mask's mouth opened.

"Below."

Above him, the creature began forcing itself into the ravine.

Kai looked down.

The ravine ended at a black slit in the rock. From inside came a breath of cold air carrying the smell of rain, mud, and something living.

The masks leaned toward the opening.

Not all of them.

Some faced Kai.

Some faced the creature.

The ones facing Kai spoke together.

"Chosen walks."

The ones facing the creature whispered a different word.

"Hunted."

Kai stared at the dark slit. His palm burned around the fragment. The black-red mark pulsed once, answering something below.

He could stay in the ravine and let the creature reach him, or enter the dark where Sora's voice had come from.

The creature's fingers found the rim above.

Kai stepped through the slit.

Behind him, the masks began to laugh.

The sound followed as he moved into the cold, and beneath it, far below the stone, something answered with Sora's voice.

"Run, Kai."



Following Cracks That Form a Map

"Don't use her voice," Kai said.

The answer came from beneath the stone.

"Kai."

It was Sora's voice, thin with distance, exactly as he remembered it when she was trying not to sound afraid. Behind him, the masks still laughed. Their noise skittered over the plain, but the voice below seemed to travel through his bones instead.

Kai tightened his grip on the broken length of bone. The white mask had marked him. He could feel the mark beneath his shirt, a cold pressure between his shoulder blades, as if a fingertip rested there and waited. The flesh-creature had followed that mark through the dust. It had known his name before he spoke it.

He faced the grey-yellow ground.

"Tell me where she is."

For a moment, nothing answered.

Then the fissures opened.

They spread from his boots in narrow black lines, branching across the plain. Some were no wider than threads. Others yawned deep enough to show a dull

yellow glow below, like light trapped beneath rotten teeth. The cracks ran toward the hazy horizon, converging around a distant smear of darkness.

A route.

Kai crouched and touched one.

Heat pulsed through the stone. The crack shivered beneath his fingers and turned slightly east.

He pulled back.

"No," he whispered.

The line turned again, pointing toward the haze.

Behind him, something scraped across the ground.

Kai looked over his shoulder.

The flesh-creature stood far off among the mask-faces. Its body seemed assembled from wet folds pulled too tightly over a frame that had never been human. One arm dragged behind it. The other hung crookedly at its side. It had stopped pursuing him, but its head leaned toward the mark on his back.

Waiting.

Kai rose. The path beneath him remained still.

He took one step.

The crack ahead widened with a dry snapping sound. A second fissure crossed it, then a third. Together they formed an arrow pointing toward the horizon.

Kai moved again.

The arrow shifted.

Not much. Its point slid a few inches to the left, but the change was enough to make him stop. He studied the surrounding lines. They ran in clean angles now, too deliberate to be natural. A long fracture curved around a patch of pale stone. Another split from it and bent toward the haze.

The pattern resembled a map drawn by someone who had seen maps only in a dream.

He planted the bone beside the nearest line.

"I mark this," he said.

The words felt foolish in the open heat.

He scraped a cross into the ground with the bone, then took three steps along the widest fissure. The stone trembled under his boots. A smell rose from the cracks - burnt dust mixed with something sweet and spoiled.

On the third step, the line vanished.

Kai froze.

The cross behind him remained. The fissure did not.

He turned in a slow circle. The plain stretched in every direction, level and empty except for the masks and the distant haze. The line he had followed had become a shallow stain in the stone. Beside it, another crack now ran toward the horizon.

It had been there before. He was certain of that.

He crouched again. The new line carried the same faint yellow glow. The same branching angle. The same promise.

"Every clue appears correct," he said.

The wasteland gave no reply.

A laugh rose behind him, but it did not belong to the masks. The flesh-creature had taken a step.

Kai shoved the bone into his belt and followed the new crack.

The heat pressed down harder as he walked. His mouth dried until his tongue felt split. The mark between his shoulders grew colder with every pace, and that cold spread outward beneath his skin. He imagined it opening like an eye.

At intervals, he found signs that seemed placed for him. A crescent-shaped stone beside the route. Three small pits in a row. A shard of the broken mask filled with faint yellow light.

He recognized the fragment. It had come from the white mask he had touched, the mask that had mimicked his thoughts and summoned the creature. It lay half-buried at the edge of the fissure, its yellow glow blinking softly.

Kai stopped above it.

The fragment whispered.

"Left."

His hand went to the bone.

The voice changed.

"Right."

He stared at the shard. Its surface reflected no sky, no dust, no face. Only a dull yellow shimmer moved within it.

"Sora?" he asked.

The fragment remained silent.

Then, in his own voice, it said, "You already know."

Kai kicked dust over it and kept walking.

The crack led him toward a low rise in the plain. From its top, the haze became clearer. It was not cloud. It hung close to the ground, a pale wall wavering in the distance. Something moved inside it, too large to identify and too slow to be mistaken for wind.

He climbed.

The fissures multiplied around his feet. From above, their pattern made more sense. Lines crossed and rejoined in broad loops, all of them bending toward the haze. One route appeared straighter than the others, cutting through a field of yellow stone.

Kai descended toward it.

Halfway down, he saw the footprints.

They were his.

The first print sat in the dust beside a crack. The second followed it. Then the third. Kai looked behind him. His own tracks led back up the rise, but the prints ahead were deeper, as if he had walked that way after carrying something heavy.

He touched one.

The dust was warm.

A sound came from the haze.

"Kai."

Sora again.

This time the voice was closer.

He started forward, then stopped himself. The creature's scraping had ceased. The silence behind him was worse than its pursuit.

Kai turned.

The flesh-creature stood at the foot of the rise.

It had crossed the distance without leaving tracks.

Its head twitched toward the footprints, then toward Kai. A seam opened across its chest. Inside, something pale shifted, folded, and pressed outward. The creature made no sound, but the mark on Kai's back tightened until his knees nearly buckled.

The cracks beneath him flashed yellow.

For one instant, the entire plain became visible as a single design.

The lines formed a vast spiral around the creature, around the masks, around Kai. At the center lay the haze.

Sora's voice came from that center.

"Don't let it bring you back."

Kai did not know whether the warning was hers or another imitation. He only knew the creature had begun climbing.

He ran.

The bone struck against his hip as he crossed the cracked plain. Dust clawed at his ankles. The route held steady for five steps, then bent sharply. He followed the bend. The haze widened ahead, and the air turned cold enough to sting his teeth.

Behind him, the creature made a wet clicking noise.

Kai glanced back.

It was closer.

He faced forward and saw the path split.

The left branch carried a row of shallow marks like teeth. The right passed beneath a slab of grey stone. At the fork, a white mask lay on its side, half-buried, its narrow split mouth aimed toward the left.

Kai stopped.

The mask turned.

Its featureless face rotated against the dust until it looked directly at him.

"Left," it said in Sora's voice.

The right-hand crack darkened.

Kai's breath caught.

The masks had lied before, but never in the same way. They had repeated his thoughts, laughed behind him, called him chosen. This was different. This was an answer offered before he had asked.

He picked up the bone.

The creature clicked again.

Kai stepped right.

The mask screamed.

The sound tore through the plain. Every buried face answered. The ground buckled beneath him, and the right-hand crack snapped shut like a mouth.

Kai fell hard on one knee. Pain shot up his leg. Dust filled his nose and tasted of metal.

When he looked up, the left branch was gone.

Only a single fissure remained, running straight toward the haze.

The mask's mouth had split wider.

"You see?" it said.

Kai drove the bone through its cheek.

The mask broke with a sharp white crack. Yellow light spilled over his hand, hot as blood. The laughter behind him stopped.

For several seconds, nothing moved.

Then the flesh-creature screamed.

It was not loud. It was deep. The sound passed through the stone and shook loose a rain of dust from the distant rise. Kai felt the mark on his back flare cold, and something inside the broken mask fragment in his fist answered.

He dropped it.

The fissure ahead brightened.

A path.

A real one, perhaps. Or the most convincing lie yet.

Kai limped forward. The haze waited beyond a wide stretch of cracked stone. With each step, the lines around him settled into place. They no longer shifted at once. They showed him a direction, clean and unmistakable.

Northwest.

Toward the pale wall.

Toward Sora's voice.

He reached the point where the ground sloped downward. There, scratched into the stone, was a shape he recognized: a small crooked cross, the mark he had made earlier.

Kai stared at it.

The cross should have been behind him, near the place where the first route disappeared.

He turned.

His footprints stretched away across the plain. The creature stood at their far end, motionless, framed by masks.

Kai looked down again.

The fissure beneath his boot curved around the cross and continued toward the haze.

He had not returned. The ground had brought the mark to him.

A whisper moved through the cracks.

"Keep walking."

Kai stepped over the cross.

The line beneath him shifted.

It did not turn toward the haze. It bent back toward his own footprints, joining the trail he had just made. One by one, the other fissures rearranged themselves around it. The straight route folded inward. The branches closed. The map became a ring.

Kai took another step.

The dust accepted his footprint.

Then the same print appeared three paces ahead.

He stopped.

Behind him, the creature began to walk.

Kai looked toward the haze. It had grown nearer, or the plain had shortened. Within its pale depth, a figure stood with Sora's posture, one hand raised against the cold.

The figure called his name.

At Kai's feet, the cracks opened into the exact shape of his last step.

And the wasteland waited for him to make it again.



Skeletal Wind Chokes His Memory

The crack beneath Kai's foot widened before he could lift it.

He jumped sideways. The ground snapped shut where he had been standing, then split again under his landing heel. Every fissure carried the shape of him. His heel. His toes. The crooked angle of his ankle. The wasteland was copying his steps faster than he could make them.

Behind him, something dragged itself through the dust.

Kai did not look back. He had seen enough of the flesh-creature to know that looking only gave it a place inside his thoughts. The sound came closer anyway: a wet pull, a pause, another wet pull. His lungs scraped against the heat. His fingers tightened around the broken length of bone he had taken from the ground.

Move.

The word arrived without a voice.

He tried to obey, but the crack ahead opened into the same narrow trench he had crossed twice already. Pale dust trembled along its edges. Far beyond it, the skeletal arch rose from the wasteland, enormous and white beneath the yellow sky. Ribs curved over the horizon like the remains of something that had died while trying to crawl away.

He had been running toward those bones for what might have been minutes or years.

Sora.

The name surfaced, thin and bright.

Kai reached for it.

The creature shrieked behind him.

The name vanished.

He stumbled. For one sick instant he could not remember why he was running, what the bone in his hand was for, or whether Kai belonged to him at all. The thought came loose from somewhere deep and drifted away like ash.

A mask half-buried beside the crack turned its featureless face toward him.

"Keep moving," it said in his voice.

Kai drove the bone through its narrow split mouth.

The mask broke with a sound like a tooth cracking. Shards scattered across the dust, their faint yellow light blinking beneath the surface. The creature lunged. Its many limbs struck the place where Kai had been, and the impact shoved him forward. He fell across the edge of the trench, caught himself on both palms, and felt the ground flex beneath his skin.

Then the first rib came down over him.

He crawled beneath it as the creature slammed into the bone behind him. The impact rolled through the skeleton. Dust poured from the arch. A deep vibration passed through the ribs and into Kai's teeth.

The corridor swallowed him.

On either side, colossal bones leaned inward, making a passage barely wider than his shoulders. Their surfaces were ridged and porous, warm in some

places and cold in others. Wind moved between them, though there was no opening ahead and no sky above except a thin strip of jaundiced light.

Kai pressed his back to the nearest rib.

The creature scraped at the entrance.

Its fingers found the bone and curled around it. Flesh stretched between them like wet cloth. Kai raised the broken bone, ready to strike, but the wind struck first.

It rushed through the corridor with a dry, hollow force. Not air. Something thinner. Something that slipped through his nose and mouth and pressed directly against the folds of his mind.

Kai gasped.

The wind whispered.

Not words at first. Syllables. Fragments. The shape of a sentence worn smooth by passing through too many mouths.

His name surfaced.

"Kai."

He clutched his head.

The voice came from the rib beside him. No - the corridor. No - the inside of his skull.

"Kai Vesper."

He knew the sound of it. He knew the weight of the second word. It had belonged to him before the wasteland, before the masks, before his shadow had been pulled loose across the ground.

The wind inhaled.

The memory tore.

Kai's surname vanished.

He struck the bone against his temple, once, hard enough to see white.

"Kai," he said aloud.

The wind answered.

"Kai."

He tried to remember where he had learned to speak. A room appeared, then collapsed. A door. A hand on a table. Sora laughing at something he had said.

Sora.

The corridor tightened around the name.

The ribs groaned. The wind became a shrill pressure that shoved into his ears. Kai dropped to one knee and covered his mouth, but the air found him through his fingers. It filled his throat with the taste of old dust and something metallic.

He saw Sora standing beneath a window.

No, beside a window.

No, somewhere with no walls at all.

Sora's face turned toward him. Kai could not hold the features in place. Eyes became hollows. Hair became smoke. The mouth opened, but the voice was his own.

"Don't let it say me."

The memory broke.

Kai lurched upright. "Sora!"

The wind stopped.

For a single breath, the corridor went silent.

At the entrance, the creature withdrew its hand.

Then every rib began to speak.

"Kai."

"Sora."

"Kai."

"Sora."

The names traveled through the bone in alternating pulses. Each repetition scraped something from him. Kai felt his childhood loosen. He felt the outline of a home disappear. Faces came forward and were erased before he could recognize them. He reached for Sora, but the wind made the reaching itself uncertain.

Was Sora a person?

A place?

A word the masks had planted?

The creature outside began to crawl into the corridor.

Kai looked ahead. The passage narrowed between two ribs, then opened around a vast central cavity. At its center lay a hollow vertebra, black inside, large enough for him to crouch within. The wind poured from it in steady bursts.

That was the throat.

He understood without knowing how. The skeleton was breathing through the hollow bones, and every breath carried away a piece of whoever entered.

The creature's limbs scraped closer.

Kai could stay and be found, or cross the corridor and lose more of himself.

He forced his fingers around the bone.

"Sora," he whispered.

The wind surged.

Kai stepped forward.

The first blast struck his chest and drove him back against the rib. Pain flashed through his ribs. He slid down, gasping, and the creature's pale bulk filled the entrance behind him. Its flesh shifted over itself, searching for a shape. A mouth opened where no mouth had been.

"Kai," it crooned.

He pushed up.

The wind hit again.

This time it brought a memory of Sora's hand gripping his wrist. The pressure was real enough to hurt. Kai saw a dark corridor, heard breathing close to his ear, and felt Sora pull him away from something that had been knocking on the other side of a door.

"Don't answer it," Sora had said.

Kai could not remember what they had been afraid of.

The creature entered the corridor.

Kai ran.

The wind battered him from the front. Each step became an argument with the ground. The ribs angled inward, forcing his shoulders sideways. Bone rasped his coat. Dust filled his eyes. Behind him, the creature dragged itself nearer, its wet movements swallowed and returned by the corridor.

"Kai," the wind said.

He kept moving.

"Kai Vesper."

He stumbled at the surname. It sounded wrong now, as if spoken about a stranger.

"Sora."

He stopped.

The creature surged behind him.

Kai turned and drove the broken bone into its reaching limb. The shard sank through flesh and struck the rib beneath. Yellow light burst from the wound. The creature convulsed, and its scream became a chorus of stolen voices.

Kai saw Sora again.

Not beneath a window. Not in a corridor.

Sora stood in a field of black glass, facing away. A thin line of pale light ran from Sora's back into the sky. It matched the line that had once dragged Kai's shadow across the wasteland.

Sora turned.

"Kai, remember where I am."

The creature tore free of the bone.

The vision vanished.

Kai seized the weapon and ran toward the hollow vertebra. The wind struck him so hard his feet left the ground. He landed on his side and felt something inside his mind split with a quiet, final click.

He could no longer remember his mother's face.

He could not remember the room with the window.

He could not remember whether he had ever lived anywhere beyond this wasteland.

But Sora remained.

The name burned through him.

Kai crawled the last distance and plunged into the black hollow.

The wind roared around the bone chamber. It compressed his body from every direction. His jaw locked. His eyes bulged with pressure. The air forced itself down his throat, and he tasted iron.

The creature struck the vertebra outside.

The chamber shuddered.

Kai wrapped both arms around the broken bone and pressed his forehead to its splintered end. Yellow light seeped across his skin.

"Sora," he said.

The wind replied with a hundred voices.

"Sora."

He said it again.

The voices faltered.

"Sora."

The hollow bone cracked.

A blast erupted through the corridor. It threw the creature backward and hurled Kai out through the opposite side of the skeleton. He struck the dust hard, rolled, and came to rest beneath a slanting rib.

For several seconds he could not move.

The sky above him had changed. The yellow haze had darkened to bruised violet. The giant bones stood behind him, their openings sealed by a skin of grey dust. Nothing moved at the entrance. The creature was gone.

Kai raised himself onto one elbow.

His hand still held the broken bone.

He searched his mind.

Kai.

The name was there.

Sora.

The name was there.

Everything around those two points had become loose and broken. He knew he had come from somewhere, but not where. He knew he had wanted to escape, but not from what. He knew Sora was waiting - or trapped, or dead - but the image of Sora's face had dissolved completely.

Only the name remained.

A whisper moved through the sealed ribs behind him.

"Kai."

He turned toward the sound.

Another voice answered from far across the wasteland, faint enough to be mistaken for wind.

"Sora."

Kai pushed himself upright.

The cracks beneath him began to form again, not in the shape of his steps this time, but in two diverging paths. One ran toward the distant haze. The other vanished behind the bones.

He stared at them until the distinction blurred.

Then something beneath the ground spoke in Sora's voice.

"Kai, I remember you."

The fissures closed.

Kai tightened his grip on the bone and started walking, carrying the name with him while the rest of himself fell away.



Kai Trades Breath for a Mask-Key

The bone grew warm in Kai's hand before the wasteland changed.

Not the heat that rose from the grey-yellow ground, nor the fever that had baked his skin since waking. This warmth pulsed from inside the bone, faint and wet, as if something beneath its splintered surface had begun to breathe.

Kai stopped.

Behind him, the closed fissures trembled. The cracks had sealed over his last step, but the ground still remembered it. A shallow outline of his boot darkened the stone. From within that mark came a soft scraping, followed by the drag of something heavy across dust.

The flesh-creature was close.

Kai looked toward the haze. It had thickened while he walked, gathering low against the horizon like smoke trapped beneath glass. Somewhere inside it lay the center of the separation. The place where the shifting routes might stop shifting. The place where Sora's voice had called to him from beneath the stone.

He needed a way through.

The bone twitched in his grip.

A line of masks rose ahead, not scattered now but heaped together in a dense mound. Faces pressed against faces, white, grey, yellowed, cracked, and blackened around their edges. Some had mouths. Some had only narrow seams.

A few wore the smooth, featureless blankness of the white mask he had touched before.

Every hollow seemed aimed at him.

Kai tightened his fingers around the broken bone and moved toward them.

"Sora," he whispered.

The name remained inside him. It was the last clean thing he possessed. He could feel the rest of his memory thinning around it, loose threads lifting in the dry wind. His mother's face had gone. The shape of his own room had gone. Even the sound of his laugh had become a stranger's noise.

Sora stayed.

The masks shifted as he approached.

A face near the top of the heap opened its mouth.

"Kai."

His own voice.

Another mask turned. "Kai."

Then another, lower down. "Kai."

The name passed through the mound until the whole heap murmured with it. The sound was not loud, but it filled the air with a pressure that made his teeth ache.

Kai raised the bone.

"I'm not here for you."

The masks answered in Sora's voice.

"Then why are you still walking?"

He flinched. The bone dipped.

The creature scraped closer behind him.

He could not see it yet. He saw its influence instead: dust lifting in a narrow trail, small stones rolling away from an unseen weight. His shadow stretched toward the mound, thinning at the edges. It looked less like a shadow than a stain being pulled from beneath him.

Kai stepped forward.

The masks gave a dry, collective click.

"What do you want?" Sora's voice asked.

"A key."

The heap shuddered.

Kai swallowed. His throat felt lined with ash. "Something that opens the route to the center."

"Open," the masks repeated.

"Route."

"Center."

The words warped as they passed between faces. By the end they sounded like bones knocking together in a sealed room.

One mask slid free and dropped onto the ground. It was small and yellowed, with a split running from its brow to its mouth. A faint yellow light glimmered in the fracture.

Kai recognized it.

A broken fragment from the white mask.

He crouched and reached for it.

The fragment snapped its mouth open.

Kai jerked back as a needle of pain pierced his palm. The shard had not moved, but a thin line of blood appeared across his skin. The yellow light brightened, and the masks began speaking at once.

"Give."

"Give."

"Give."

The creature made a sound behind him, low and moist.

Kai turned.

It stood at the edge of the mound's shadow.

Its body had no fixed shape. Flesh sagged from a frame that might once have been human, then tightened and rearranged itself as though searching for a better arrangement. Its limbs bent too many times. Its head leaned to one side. Where its face should have been, skin folded over skin, opening and closing without eyes.

Kai's hand went to the bone.

The creature said nothing.

It only watched him with the blank attention of something waiting for a door to open.

Kai faced the masks again. "What do you want?"

The heap answered with his voice.

"Breath."

The word entered him like cold water.

He remembered the skeletal wind. He remembered choking beneath the arch while pieces of himself tore loose. He remembered clinging to Sora's name as everything else broke apart.

"No."

The masks tilted toward him.

"Breath."

"I need it."

"Need."

"Need."

The creature shifted closer. Its foot - or the thing that served as one - pressed into the dust. The ground puckered beneath it.

Kai backed toward the mound. The masks were behind him now, a wall of faces. The creature waited in front. Between them, the air tasted of rust and old salt.

"Take something else," he said.

The mound went silent.

Kai looked down at the bone in his hand. The weapon had been broken long before he found it, but its edge was still sharp enough to cut. He could offer

blood. Skin. A finger. Anything that left him able to breathe, able to remember Sora, able to reach the haze.

One mask near his knee whispered, "Not enough."

Another said, "Not yours to give."

The words struck deeper than they should have.

Kai stared at his hand. The fingers looked too pale. At the tips, the skin had become translucent. Beneath it, faint lines of yellow light traced the bones.

His breath caught.

The creature leaned forward.

"Kai," it said.

Not his voice this time.

Sora's.

Kai shut his eyes. For a moment he was somewhere else: a dark room, Sora beside him, her shoulder touching his. He could not see her face. He could not remember what she had been saying. He knew only that she had been alive in that moment, and that he had promised to find her.

The memory narrowed to a single sensation.

Her hand closing around his.

Kai opened his eyes.

"What happens if I give it?"

The masks answered together.

"Less."

"Less what?"

"Less Kai."

His grip tightened around the bone until the splintered end cut his palm.

The creature came nearer. The air around it trembled with a faint sucking sound. His shadow had stretched almost to its feet.

Kai looked at the haze.

Then at the mound.

"I give you my breath," he said.

The masks leaned toward him.

"But I keep Sora."

A face near the center cracked from cheek to cheek. Yellow light poured through the opening.

"Keep," it said.

The mound opened.

Not outward. Downward.

Masks rolled aside, revealing a hollow packed with smaller faces. They were fused together, their edges softened as if melted. At the bottom lay a long piece of pale bone, curved like a key. Its shaft was thin and ridged. Its end split into three uneven teeth.

It pulsed with the same yellow light as the fragment.

Kai felt the first breath leave him before he moved.

His lungs contracted. Air rushed from his mouth in a visible stream, white despite the heat. The masks drank it. Their hollows darkened as the breath poured into them.

Pain seized his chest.

He dropped to one knee.

The creature lunged.

Kai swung the broken bone. It struck the creature's arm with a wet crack. The impact knocked him sideways, but the flesh recoiled, its limb folding inward. A smell like hot meat and damp stone filled the air.

The masks continued to draw.

Kai tried to inhale.

Nothing came.

His throat worked uselessly. His ribs pulled inward. The world narrowed around the yellow glow in the hollow.

He reached for Sora's name.

It was there.

Sora.

He clung to it while another breath tore free.

The masks made a sound like a thousand small sighs. The bone-key lifted from the hollow and hovered above the heap.

Kai crawled toward it.

The creature recovered behind him. Its fingers dragged across the ground, leaving grooves that smoked at the edges.

"Kai," it called in Sora's voice. "Stop."

He almost did.

The voice carried the exact break in Sora's speech, the slight roughness that came when she was afraid but trying not to show it. He knew that voice. He had heard it in a stairwell, in a car, through a half-closed door.

But the memory had no face.

Only the voice remained.

Kai reached for the key.

His fingertips touched the bone.

The masks screamed.

The sound punched through his skull. He saw the wasteland split into overlapping versions of itself: one buried in snow, one drowned beneath black water, one filled with doors standing upright in the dust. In every version, Sora stood beyond a threshold.

In every version, she turned away.

Kai closed his hand around the key.

The scream stopped.

Air slammed back into his lungs.

He inhaled once, violently. The breath tasted wrong. It was cold and metallic, carrying a faint whisper beneath it. When he exhaled, the sound did not come from his mouth alone. Something inside his chest exhaled with him.

The creature halted.

Kai rose, clutching the mask-key.

The mound collapsed behind him. Faces slid over one another, sealing the hollow. The broken fragment at his feet went dark.

The creature stared at the key.

For the first time, it seemed uncertain.

Kai lifted the bone.

A thin line of light ran along its ridges. Far across the wasteland, the haze opened into a narrow vertical seam.

The route.

The center waited beyond it.

Kai took one step toward the opening.

His lungs tightened.

He stopped and pressed a hand to his chest. Each breath came shallowly now. Between inhale and exhale was a pause he could not control, as if another set of lungs had to finish before his own could begin.

He looked down.

Yellow lines had spread beneath the skin of his wrist, branching toward his elbow. His hand felt numb. The fingers no longer closed quite as he commanded them.

Behind him, the masks began to whisper.

"Less Kai."

The creature moved away from the mound, following.

Kai turned toward the seam in the haze.

"Sora," he said.

His voice came out doubled.

One voice was his.

The other breathed from somewhere deeper, borrowing the shape of his words.

"Sora."

The seam widened.

Kai walked into it, carrying the key, while something inside his chest learned the rhythm of being alive.

CHAPTER 6

The Bone-Key Opens a Doorless Wall

The wall of dust stood where the wasteland had been empty a moment before.

Kai stopped with the mask-key raised in his hand. Yellow light pulsed through the pale bone, answering the rhythm that had begun inside his chest. Behind him, something dragged itself over the cracked ground. Each scrape came closer, though the creature made no sound of breathing.

The dust wall climbed beyond sight, a vertical storm packed hard enough to resemble stone. Grains struck its surface and vanished without falling. There was no opening, no seam, no shadow beneath it. Yet the fissures at Kai's feet all pointed toward the same blank place.

He needed to cross.

The thought arrived with Sora's name attached to it, thin but intact. Sora. He held it between his teeth like a splinter.

"Not here," he whispered.

The wall gave no answer. The creature did.

"Kai."

Its voice borrowed his again, but the sound came from behind him in Sora's tone.

He turned.

The flesh-creature crouched at the end of the nearest fissure. Its body had no stable shape. Limbs pressed out of its torso and withdrew. A pale mask was lodged in its shoulder, half swallowed by wet folds. The hollows meant for eyes faced him.

"Kai," it said, and this time Sora's voice broke on the name.

His grip tightened around the bone-key. The creature lowered itself, preparing to spring.

Kai ran.

The ground split beneath his boots. A crack opened, snapped shut, and opened again farther ahead, forcing him to leap from one strip of grey-yellow earth to another. Heat climbed through the soles of his feet. His left hand had begun to stiffen; the fingers bent with a faint clicking, as if small joints were assembling beneath the skin.

The wall waited ahead, impossible and close.

He reached it and struck his palm against the dust.

Nothing.

The impact shuddered through his arm. Dust pressed back, cold now, and the key's yellow pulse faltered.

Behind him, the creature crossed the fissure in a single boneless lurch.

Kai looked down at the key. Its curved end had a notch like a tooth. He had taken it from the masks after giving them his breath. It had opened nothing because he had asked it to open nothing. The realization came not as thought but as pressure behind his eyes.

A lock required a place to turn.

His hand moved before fear could stop it. He pushed the key into the wall.

The bone entered as if the dust were deep water.

A line of yellow light spread from the point of contact. It drew the shape of a door: two vertical strokes, a lintel, no handle. Beyond the outline, the wall darkened.

The creature struck him.

Its fingers closed around his ankle. The grip was soft, almost gentle, and filled with shifting pulses. Kai fell hard, scraping his palms against the ground. The key remained buried in the wall.

"Kai," the thing murmured. "Let me through."

He kicked. The creature's hand tightened. Something pushed beneath his trouser leg, probing the skin with cold, searching pressure.

Kai reached for the key. His fingers found its shaft, but the bone had fused with the wall.

The door brightened.

For one heartbeat, the dust became transparent.

Kai saw a corridor beyond it, narrow and black, lined with white masks. Their mouths were open. At the far end stood Sora, or the shape of her, one hand pressed against the darkness.

"Kai."

Her voice came from the corridor.

He pulled.

The key tore free with a sound like a tooth being ripped from a jaw. The door opened inward, though nothing moved it. Blackness spilled across the ground.

The creature hauled him backward.

Kai drove the broken bone into its wrist.

The flesh split around the weapon. Yellow light leaked from the wound. The creature recoiled, and its grip loosened just enough.

Kai crawled toward the opening.

The door had already begun to narrow. Dust folded inward along its edges, grinding against itself. He shoved his fingers through the gap. Something seized his coat from behind.

He did not look back.

With his free hand, he jammed the mask-key into the floor beyond the threshold. The bone struck something hard. The corridor rang like a hollow skull.

The creature pulled.

Kai's shoulder wrenched. The fabric tore. His body slid backward across the boundary, half in darkness and half in the wasteland.

"Sora!" he shouted.

The figure at the corridor's end turned.

Its face was featureless.

The door narrowed to the width of Kai's ribs.

He twisted, abandoning the coat. The creature's grip slipped from cloth to skin. Three fingers hooked into his side.

Pain flashed white.

Kai bit down on the name in his mouth and threw himself forward.

The fingers tore free.

He landed inside the corridor as the door slammed shut behind him.

For several seconds he could hear only the blood moving in his ears. Then the wall sealed with a deep, granular thud.

Kai pushed himself upright. The corridor was not made of stone. Its surfaces flexed faintly, as though something immense breathed beneath them. White masks protruded from both sides, their cracked mouths whispering fragments of his thoughts.

Sora.

Bone.

Breath.

The key lay across his palm. Its light had dimmed to a weak yellow ember.

Kai touched his side. Blood warmed his fingers. The wound was narrow, but the skin around it twitched.

He waited for the creature to break through the wall.

Nothing came.

A laugh rose from inside him.

Kai froze.

It was not loud. It trembled through his ribs, passed beneath his sternum, and faded into the corridor's living walls. He pressed both hands against his chest.

The rhythm inside him changed.

Something had entered with him.

"No," Kai said.

His voice came from his throat and from beneath his skin.

The flesh around the wound puckered. A dark line traveled upward beneath it, branching toward his ribs. He clawed at the mark. Skin peeled under his nails, revealing not muscle but a pale, fibrous layer that flexed in time with the thing in his chest.

The creature had not followed through the door.

It had followed through him.

Kai staggered toward the corridor's far end. The masks turned as he passed. Their blank faces tracked him. One cracked open along the cheek, and a wet finger emerged from inside.

He swung the broken bone.

The mask snapped shut. The blow chipped its edge, releasing a burst of yellow dust that stung his eyes.

"Get out," Kai said.

The thing beneath his ribs answered in Sora's voice.

"Where?"

He stopped.

The corridor stretched ahead, but its length had changed. The figure he had seen beyond the door stood only a few steps away now. It wore Sora's outline: narrow shoulders, dark hair, one hand held against its chest.

Kai raised the bone.

The figure smiled without moving its mouth.

"You carried the door," it said.

"No."

"You carried me."

The mark beneath Kai's skin reached his throat. His jaw clicked. For an instant, he felt another mouth forming behind his own, opening and closing against the back of his tongue.

He slammed his head into the nearest wall.

The masks rattled. Pain burst across his skull. The thing inside him went silent.

Kai struck again.

The wall softened beneath his forehead. A mask sank into it and emerged behind his eyes - not physically, but in the place where sight became thought. He saw the wasteland outside, flattened and distant. The creature stood before the sealed wall, its body pressed against the dust as if listening.

Then it lifted its head.

Its face was changing.

Flesh drew inward around the white mask in its shoulder. Limbs folded into a shape like Kai's. One hand rose and touched the wall exactly where his palm had been.

Inside the corridor, Kai felt the same touch.

His own palm burned.

He looked down. A pale ridge had appeared across it, curved like the key. Yellow light pulsed beneath the skin.

The creature outside moved its fingers.

Kai's fingers moved with them.

He tried to clench his hand. The muscles obeyed late, fighting something else. The key slipped from his palm and struck the floor.

The figure shaped like Sora came closer.

"Kai," it said. "Keep walking."

He snatched up the key.

The corridor's masks began to speak at once. Some used his voice. Some used Sora's. Others made sounds too low for language, vibrations that loosened dust from the ceiling.

Kai forced one foot forward.

The thing in his chest shifted with pleasure.

He took another step. The wall beneath his skin tightened around his ribs. A line of flesh rose along his forearm, dividing and rejoining like a mouth learning how to close.

He wanted to turn back. There was no door behind him now. Only the wall, smooth and pale, with his torn coat fused into it like a stain.

The creature had been left outside.

The creature was also inside.

At the corridor's end, the false Sora reached for him.

Kai lifted the mask-key between them. Its yellow light flared, and every mask along the walls opened its mouth.

The sound that came out was his name.

Not spoken.

Breathed.

The figure vanished. The corridor folded around Kai, pulling him forward through a passage that had not existed before. He stumbled, caught himself, and felt a second pulse answer his own beneath the skin of his wrist.

Ahead, darkness opened into a wider place.

Behind him, his body smiled.

CHAPTER 7

A Hundred Masks Split Into Two Fates

Kai turned before the smile behind him could become a face.

The corridor had already narrowed. White masks pressed from the walls, their cracked mouths opening and closing without sound. Beyond them, darkness widened into a chamber where the dust lay flat and pale, strewn with faces.

Kai stepped into it, the mask-key clenched in his right hand. Its faint yellow pulse moved through his palm and up his arm. Something moved with it beneath his skin.

He felt the thing inside him listening.

"Sora," he whispered.

The chamber answered.

"Sora."

The voice came from everywhere and nowhere. It was almost hers. That almost cut deeper than the creature's claws had.

Kai crossed the dust toward it.

The ground split beneath his boot.

He lurched aside as a line opened from heel to horizon, spilling a breath of furnace heat. Masks shifted in the dust around the fissure. Some rolled faceup.

Others rose on edges that were not edges at all but thin, pale fingers pushing from below.

Every face turned toward him.

The old white mask lay nearest, half-buried and cracked across its featureless brow. Its shallow eye hollows filled with yellow light.

"Choose," it said in Kai's voice.

"No."

The masks whispered the word back, each with a different mouth.

No. No. No.

Kai raised the broken bone. The thing in his chest tightened, pulling his ribs inward. His own hand trembled, though he could not tell whether the trembling belonged to him.

"I'm not choosing for you," he said.

The white mask tilted.

"Already chosen."

A tremor traveled through the ground. Dust lifted in rings around Kai's boots. Beneath it, more masks pushed upward, one after another, until the chamber became a field of faces. Their surfaces bore no features, but every hollow seemed to hold a different expression. Grief. Hunger. Recognition.

Then the masks began to peel away.

They tore themselves from the earth with wet, brittle sounds. Dust clung to their backs in grey sheets. Some came free whole. Others split down the middle, and from each broken half a narrow neck of bone extended, jointed like an insect's leg.

Kai backed toward the corridor.

The doorway was gone.

Behind him, the wall had sealed itself smooth. No seam. No lock. Only a faint impression of his own smiling mouth in the dust.

The masks moved toward the center of the chamber. Hundreds of them dragged themselves across the ground, scraping white paths through the grey. They gathered around two fissures that ran side by side into the dark.

The paths were identical.

Each began at Kai's feet. Each crossed the same field of masks. Each disappeared beneath the same distant haze.

The left path carried a low vibration through the soles of his boots.

The right carried a smell of rain.

Kai stopped breathing.

Rain belonged to somewhere else. Somewhere with wet pavement, rusted railings, and Sora laughing because he had forgotten an umbrella. The memory appeared whole for one impossible second. Her hand in his. A strand of dark hair stuck to her cheek. The sound of water striking a metal roof.

Then the thing inside him reached for it.

The memory tore.

Kai folded over, pressing the broken bone against his sternum. A second voice spoke from behind his teeth.

"Give it."

He spat onto the dust. "You don't get her."

The flesh-creature unfolded from his shadow.

It did not rise all at once. First came a long hand, palm-down, its fingers sewn from strips of glistening flesh. Then a shoulder. Then the suggestion of a head, smooth and unfinished. It pulled itself free as though Kai's shadow were a membrane.

Its smile had learned his.

"Sora is not yours," it said.

The masks turned toward the creature. Their mouths opened. A dry chorus passed through them, too soft to understand.

The creature flinched.

Kai saw the hesitation and moved.

He lunged for the right-hand path, the one carrying the scent of rain. The masks nearest him snapped shut. Their mouths became hard seams. A row of them rose from the ground, blocking his way.

Kai swung the broken bone.

The first mask shattered. Yellow light burst from its hollow center and burned across his knuckles. The pain made his fingers loosen, but he struck again. A second mask split. A third clamped onto the bone.

Its surface softened around the weapon.

Kai pulled. The mask held.

The creature came closer behind him, dragging the darkness of his shadow across the dust. His legs weakened as it drew near.

"Let go," the mask whispered.

Kai twisted the bone and drove the mask-key into its cracked brow.

The pale key entered as if the mask had been waiting for it. Yellow light flooded the fracture. The mask convulsed, releasing the broken bone, and began to speak in Sora's voice.

"Kai, don't."

He froze.

The sound was exact. Not almost. Exact.

His throat closed. The chamber vanished beneath the memory of Sora saying his name in a dark room, softly, as though she feared waking something.

The creature's fingers touched his back.

Kai drove his elbow behind him. Flesh gave way with a damp pop. The creature recoiled, and the false voice broke into a wet hiss.

The mask-key remained buried in the white mask.

Kai gripped it with both hands and pulled.

The mask came free of the ground.

Underneath it was not soil but a small black opening, deep enough to contain a night sky. Stars moved inside it, too many and too close together. One of them blinked.

A voice rose from the hole.

"Kai."

This time it was Sora.

He nearly answered.

The opening widened. The two paths shuddered. On the left, the masks began to move faster, rushing toward the darkness as if fleeing a fire. On the right, they arranged themselves along the fissure, faceup and silent.

The white mask in Kai's hands grew warm.

"Two nightmares," it said. "One keeps what you lost."

Kai stared at the paths.

"What does the other keep?"

"What remains."

The creature struck.

Kai threw himself forward. Its claws grazed his shoulder and opened the skin. Heat spilled down his arm. He landed on the right-hand path, the mask-key skidding from his fingers.

The fissure beneath him closed.

For one breath, the world became solid.

Then the masks began to peel away from the ground on both sides.

They rose in pairs, identical faces splitting from identical patches of dust. Each pair looked at Kai, then at the path beside it. Some turned left. Some turned right. Their bodies stretched into pale, crawling figures, and each chose a direction with a terrible, deliberate certainty.

The left-hand figures carried scraps of sound. Kai heard a door slam. A child crying. His own voice saying words he could not remember.

The right-hand figures carried Sora's echo.

"Kai."

"Kai, wait."

"Kai, I know where we are."

He pressed his hands over his ears. The voices entered through his teeth.

The creature crawled onto the ground behind him. Its wounded elbow had sealed. The smile on its face widened.

"Take the left," it said. "You can be complete."

Kai looked down.

The right path shone faintly beneath the dust, its cracks filled with the same yellow light as the mask-key. At its far end, beyond the haze, something moved like a woman standing in deep water.

Sora.

Or the shape that had worn her in the corridor.

Kai's memories began to loosen.

He forgot the color of Sora's eyes.

He forgot whether she had ever held his hand.

He forgot the sound of his own mother's voice, though he could not remember having one.

The masks on the left opened their mouths.

"Come back," they said.

The creature reached for his ankle.

Kai snatched up the mask-key.

The thing inside his chest surged toward his hand, eager, almost joyful. Black threads moved beneath his skin, converging around the pale bone. His fingers began to stiffen. The joints lengthened. The hand holding the key no longer looked entirely human.

He could use the key on the ground.

He understood that without knowing how.

A lock waited beneath each path.

The left lock was shaped like a mouth.

The right was shaped like an eye.

The creature's claws closed around his ankle.

Kai fell to one knee. Dust filled his mouth. It tasted of old teeth and hot metal.

"Sora!" he shouted.

The echo answered from the right.

"Kai!"

He slammed the mask-key into the fissure.

The ground opened like an eyelid.

Yellow light poured upward, not outward, illuminating the underside of the wasteland. Beneath the dust lay a vast arrangement of paths, all of them crossing, separating, and crossing again. Each route held a different Kai. One ran with the flesh-creature behind him. One stood motionless beneath the skeletal arch. One wore a white mask over his face. One had no face at all.

The creature screamed.

Its grip tightened, crushing bone in Kai's ankle. Kai seized the broken bone with his free hand and drove it into the creature's wrist.

The flesh parted.

The creature did not release him. Instead, it leaned close, its unfinished head brushing his cheek.

"You cannot reach her without leaving something."

Kai looked into the smooth place where its eyes should have been.

"I already did."

He wrenched his ankle free and shoved the mask-key deeper.

The right-hand path opened.

Not into a door. Into a long descent lined with pale masks. At the bottom, rain fell through darkness. Its sound was unmistakable.

Sora's voice came from below.

"Kai, please."

The left path closed with a grinding roar.

For an instant, Kai saw what it held: a room made from his missing memories. Sora stood inside it, alive and furious, calling his name. Behind her waited every face he had forgotten. The room folded inward as the masks sealed over it.

Kai reached toward the vision.

A sharp pain crossed his skull.

The memory of Sora's eyes vanished.

He screamed, but the right-hand opening pulled him forward. The creature clung to his back, its body flattening against him, its mouth pressed to the base of his neck.

The masks along the descent began to laugh in Sora's voice.

Kai drove the mask-key backward.

It struck the creature beneath the jaw.

Yellow light erupted through its body. The thing tore away from him and fell across the left path, where the closing dust swallowed it to the waist. Its hands clawed at the ground.

"Kai," it said, no longer smiling. "You chose wrong."

Kai crawled into the right-hand passage.

The opening narrowed behind him. He dragged his injured leg forward, leaving a dark trail across the pale floor. Rain touched his face, cold enough to hurt. He lifted his head.

At the bottom of the descent, a figure stood beneath the falling water.

Sora's outline.

Her face remained hidden by the dark.

Kai gripped the mask-key until its edges cut into his altered palm.

"Sora?"

The figure raised one hand.

Behind Kai, the last seam in the ground closed.

Somewhere beneath it, his lost memories began to knock.

CHAPTER 8

Sora's Flesh Room Answers Through Pain

"Stop moving," Sora said. "If that's you, stop."

The thing beneath her answered by tightening.

Wet flesh pressed against her back, warm as fever and slick beneath the thin fabric of her shirt. Curtains hung around her in overlapping folds, pale red and veined blue, swaying without wind. Somewhere beyond them, something scraped a metal tray across the floor.

Sora tried to lift her head. A thread of tissue stretched from her cheek to the wall and snapped with a soft, elastic sound.

Pain flared through her jaw.

Not her jaw.

A second pain arrived inside the first, distant and sharper, as if someone had driven a needle beneath her ribs. It came with a tremor through the room. Every hanging curtain shuddered. The tray stopped scraping.

Sora held still.

"Kai?"

The name left her throat as a rasp. She had not heard her own voice since waking. Her mouth tasted of iron and bitter milk. Her wrists were pinned

beneath bands of flesh that flexed with her pulse.

The distant pain came again.

One strike. A pause. Two quick strikes.

Sora clenched her teeth against the next wave. It began behind her left eye, traveled down her neck, and ended in the center of her chest. The room responded with a wet contraction. Curtains drew together, closing the gaps between them.

"No," she whispered.

The flesh beneath her shifted. A seam opened beside her ear, revealing a dark cavity lined with small, glistening teeth. It did not bite. It listened.

Sora pulled against the bands. They tightened until her fingers went numb.

"I need to find him."

The cavity widened.

A sound came from inside it, low and bubbling. Not words. Not yet.

She remembered Kai's hands around the bone-shaped mask-key, the faint yellow light pulsing through it. She remembered the doorless wall opening beneath the pale bone. She remembered his face turning toward the false shape wearing her likeness.

Behind him, the last seam in the ground had closed.

Somewhere beneath it, his lost memories had begun to knock.

Sora had felt the knocking here.

It had entered her body as pressure beneath the sternum, then vanished when the room's caretakers came. She had never seen their faces. They moved

behind the flesh curtains, their hands pale and jointed, their tools clean. Each time they cut into her, they took something that was not blood. A sound. A memory. Once, the exact shape of Kai's mouth when he said her name.

She had to reach him before they took the name itself.

The pain returned.

One strike. Pause. Two quick strikes.

Sora breathed through it, though the room had made breathing difficult. The air smelled of salt, copper, and something sweet rotting under heat. Her ribs rose against the slick surface. The bands around her wrists pulsed in time with the pain.

She counted silently.

"One," she said. "Then two."

The room answered with a twitch.

Sora stared at the curtain above her. A dark vein ran through it, branching into three smaller veins and then into a pattern of pale knots. The knots moved when the distant pain came.

One.

Two.

The first pulse made the vein swell. The second and third made the knots close.

She waited.

The pattern repeated.

Sora's terror loosened just enough for thought to enter.

It was not random. The room was not merely hurting her. Something was passing through it.

"Kai," she said again, more carefully. "If you can hear me, do it again."

Silence filled the flesh room.

Then the pain struck once.

Sora's eyes burned. She pulled her right hand free by twisting until the band tore skin from her wrist. Warm fluid ran into her palm. The room gave a startled shiver.

The caretakers moved beyond the curtains.

She heard them now: soft feet, wet soles, the click of instruments touching one another.

Sora reached toward the vein.

Her fingertips sank into the curtain. It was not fabric. It was a thin layer of living membrane stretched over something hard. The membrane folded around her fingers and drew them deeper.

A flash crossed her mind.

Kai standing beneath the skeletal arch, dust whitening his hair.

Another pulse.

Kai turning with the broken bone raised in his hand.

Another.

His breath leaving him as the masks opened their narrow mouths.

Sora cried out and yanked her hand free. The vision collapsed into a smear of yellow light. Her palm came away marked with a branching line, bright beneath the skin.

"Kai!"

The cavity beside her ear shaped itself around the sound. The teeth withdrew. A tongue, pale and translucent, pushed through the opening.

"Ka - "

It tried to copy her.

Sora struck it with her bleeding hand.

The impact made the whole room convulse. Flesh curtains whipped against one another. A tray overturned beyond them, scattering metal instruments across the floor.

The caretakers hurried closer.

Sora twisted toward the cavity. "You don't get to use his name."

The tongue withdrew.

For a moment, nothing moved except the fluid sliding down her wrist.

Then the distant pain came in a new rhythm.

Two strikes. One. Two.

Sora froze.

She pressed her fingertips to the glowing branch in her palm. The mark throbbed beneath them.

"Two, one, two," she whispered.

The room tightened around her ribs.

"No. That isn't enough."

She looked through the narrow opening between the curtains. The floor beyond was made of overlapping slabs of flesh, each one rising and falling like a sleeping chest. At the far end stood a basin filled with black water. Something floated in it, pale and curved.

A bone.

The mask-key's twin, perhaps. Or a piece of Kai already severed from him.

Sora could not reach the basin while pinned. The caretakers were almost there. Their shadows pressed through the curtains, long and thin, their heads bent at impossible angles.

She pulled her knees toward her chest.

The band around her ankle resisted. She pulled harder.

Pain burst from her calf, and the distant signal answered.

Two strikes. One. Two.

The caretakers stopped.

Sora understood then. The room carried pain in both directions. Her body was not only receiving Kai's movements. It was sending them back.

She had been mistaking the answer for another attack.

"Kai," she said, forcing the words through clenched teeth. "Listen for the pain."

The nearest caretaker pushed through the curtain.

Its hand entered first, carrying a narrow instrument with a hooked tip. The fingers were human in number but not in arrangement, two thumbs folded against the palm. No face followed. Only a smooth, stretched hood, damp and trembling.

Sora kicked.

The hook touched her thigh. A line of fire opened beneath it.

Far away, something struck twice.

Sora screamed once, then forced herself to speak.

"Two."

The caretaker's hood tilted.

The pain came again. One.

"One."

The hook pressed deeper.

Two.

"Two."

The caretaker pulled the instrument away. A filament followed it from her thigh, thin as fishing line. It stretched toward the basin and trembled.

The other caretakers began to gather.

Sora saw the message now, not as words but as pressure, movement, consequence. Kai was moving. He was somewhere beyond the closed seam, somewhere the room could touch but not yet hold.

She needed to answer him.

The caretaker lifted the hook again.

Sora drove her free hand into the wound in her thigh.

The room convulsed.

The pain that answered was enormous. It came from everywhere at once: her teeth, her spine, the soft meat behind her eyes. Beneath it, buried like a rhythm under thunder, came the signal.

One. Two. Two. One.

Sora repeated it aloud.

"One. Two. Two. One."

The flesh curtains began to pulse.

The caretakers turned toward one another. Their hoods opened along vertical seams, revealing not mouths but rows of tiny vibrating cords. The cords plucked the rhythm from the air.

Sora felt Kai's response before it arrived. A dragging motion. A stumble. The sudden pressure of something entering him.

Then the signal broke.

Sora sagged against the wall.

"Kai?"

Nothing.

The caretakers advanced. Their instruments clicked in anticipation. One carried a shallow bowl. Another held a spool of red thread. The third reached toward Sora's glowing palm.

"No."

She tried to crawl, but the ankle band cinched tight. The floor beneath her softened, opening around her knees.

The caretaker touched the mark.

A memory tore loose.

Kai's voice, breathless and raw: Sora, don't look back.

The memory hung between them as a thread of light.

Sora watched it drift toward the caretaker's hand.

"No!"

She seized the thread with her teeth.

It tasted of dust and blood. The caretaker pulled. The thread cut across her tongue, but Sora held on. Behind the pain, she heard Kai again - not words this time, but the rough rhythm of his breath after the masks had taken it.

Inhale.

Pause.

A broken exhale.

She matched it.

The room recoiled.

The curtains ripped from their ceiling hooks and fell in heavy folds. The caretakers staggered. The basin at the far end overturned, and the pale bone inside struck the floor.

Sora tore her ankle free.

She crawled toward it while the room thrashed. Flesh slapped against her shoulders. A curtain wrapped her waist and began drawing her backward. She dug her fingers into the seams between the floor slabs and dragged herself forward.

The bone lay just beyond reach.

Another signal pulsed through her body.

One. Two. Two. One.

Sora extended her hand.

The bone rolled toward her.

Not by itself. A thin cord of flesh had tied itself around one end. It pulled once, then stopped, waiting.

Sora understood the bargain without knowing who had made it.

She seized the bone.

The room screamed.

Every curtain opened at once. The sound was wet, vast, and layered with voices. Some spoke Kai's name. Some spoke hers. Some repeated the rhythm until it became a demand.

The caretakers rushed her.

Sora drove the bone into the nearest one.

It entered the smooth hood with almost no resistance. The creature folded around it, shuddering. No blood came out. Instead, a stream of black water poured from the wound and spread across the floor.

The other two seized Sora's arms.

She fought them, but they were stronger. Their fingers sank into her flesh. The glowing branch in her palm brightened beneath the pressure.

"Two," Sora gasped.

The distant answer came.

Two.

"One."

One.

"Two."

Two.

The caretakers jerked her upright.

They had heard it.

Their hands changed. Fingers split, dividing into fine hooked tendrils that threaded beneath her skin. One found the glowing mark. Another entered the wound in her thigh. The third pressed beneath her ribs.

Sora screamed as the room began harvesting the response itself.

The rhythm did not fade. It multiplied.

Kai's movements came through her in jagged waves: a step, a fall, the scrape of bone against stone. She felt him turn toward something that wore her face. Felt the foreign pressure inside his chest. Felt the mask-key pulse like a second heart.

And beneath all of it, she felt him searching.

Sora clutched the bone until its edge cut her palm.

"Kai," she said.

The caretakers pulled.

The pain became a bridge.

"Kai, it's me."

The room opened beneath her feet.

She fell only a few inches before the flesh caught her, suspending her above the black water. The caretakers drew the glowing rhythm from her body in strands, winding it around their hands. Each strand beat with the pattern.

One. Two. Two. One.

Across the dark, Kai answered.

Sora smiled despite the blood in her mouth.

Then the room tightened its grip, and the next response came out of her as a scream that was no longer entirely hers.



The Flesh Creatures Learn Her Weaknesses

Sora's scream struck the room and came back wearing her voice.

It rose from the pulsing walls, thin and ragged, then answered itself from the feeding apparatus beside her. The apparatus opened along its length. Wet folds peeled apart, revealing a dark throat ringed with pale teeth.

She clenched her jaw.

The room tightened around her wrists. Flesh pressed her shoulders into the warm wall, and beneath her spine something beat in time with the signal she had decoded. Three slow pulses. Two quick. Three slow.

Kai.

The thought arrived before she could stop it. So did the tremor in her left hand.

The apparatus shuddered.

A strand of tissue uncoiled from its mouth and turned toward her.

"No," Sora whispered.

The room repeated it.

No.

The word came from the ceiling, from the floor, from the seam beneath her ribs. Each copy carried a different shade of terror. One pleaded. One sobbed. One laughed softly.

Sora stared at the feeding throat. She wanted only one thing: to get off the harvesting route before it finished taking whatever memory the caretakers had selected. The thought of Kai had brought the last response. If they pulled that memory free, the creatures might learn more than his name. They might learn how to reach him.

She tested her right wrist. The restraint yielded a fraction, slick and hot.

The apparatus clicked.

A second tendril emerged, thinner than the first, and brushed the air near her face. It did not touch her. It waited.

Sora stopped breathing.

The tendril withdrew.

Her pulse hammered once against her throat.

It returned at once.

The creature had not guessed. It had watched.

Across the room, the caretakers stood in their pale folds, their faces hidden beneath membranes that quivered when the apparatus moved. They had been silent since the scream. That silence felt worse than their tools. No command. No warning. Only attention.

Sora tried to slow her breathing.

In through the nose. Out through the mouth.

The wall copied her. Its whole surface drew inward, then released a damp, muscular sigh.

The tendril adjusted to the rhythm.

Her fear was no longer private. It had become a signal.

Sora forced her eyes away from the apparatus and searched the room. The floor sloped toward it in concentric ridges. Every ridge flexed when she moved. The restraints were not separate from the chamber. They were branches of the same body, grown around her because she had pulled against them before.

The caretakers had learned that, too.

She remembered the first time she had fought. The wall had tightened at her elbows. The second time, it had closed over her fingers. When she had thought of Kai, the room had sent pain through her teeth until his name broke apart.

Now the flesh-creatures were learning the shape of her reactions.

A pulse moved through the floor.

Three slow. Two quick. Three slow.

Sora's chest constricted.

The apparatus opened wider.

"No," she said again, but this time she shaped the word without sound.

The wall answered anyway.

Her fear had become louder than her voice.

One of the caretakers leaned toward her. Its head was smooth and wet, without eyes, but Sora felt its attention settle on her mouth.

"Stop," she said.

The room made the word beautiful.

Stop.

The tendril snapped forward.

Sora twisted her head aside. It grazed her cheek, cold as underground water, and a line of numbness spread beneath her skin. The apparatus convulsed. The floor dragged her hips toward the open throat.

She jerked against the restraints.

Pain flashed through her shoulders.

The creatures copied the movement. The wall pulled harder.

Sora cried out.

The feeding apparatus widened.

For one sick instant, she saw what waited inside: not a stomach, but a corridor of folded tissue, each fold carrying a different fragment of sound. Her scream moved through it in pieces. Her mother's voice. Kai's voice. Her own voice from years ago, before the room had found her.

The apparatus was not merely feeding.

It was sorting.

The caretakers had chosen a route through her.

Sora shut her eyes. Behind them, Kai stood in the corridor lined with white masks. She saw the false smile behind him, the smile that had belonged to his body before it became a face. She saw him turning. She saw the last seam close beneath him.

Somewhere beneath it, his lost memories had begun to knock.

The room sensed the memory.

The restraint around her left wrist loosened.

Sora opened her eyes.

The apparatus had shifted its attention toward the thought of Kai. Its tendrils angled toward her temple, following the memory as if it were scent. The caretakers lifted their heads together.

She understood then. The creatures did not only respond to fear. They hunted the moment fear pointed somewhere.

Sora let the memory deepen.

Kai's hand around the mask-key. The faint yellow light. The bone pressing into his palm.

The apparatus leaned closer.

She pictured him dying.

The room surged.

Its grip released her left wrist entirely and slammed her toward the feeding throat.

Sora had expected the pull. She drove her freed hand into the nearest fold of tissue.

It was soft, then hard. Something beneath it flexed around her fingers.

She seized the fold and pulled.

The room screamed with her.

The sound burst from every surface, and the caretakers recoiled. Their membranes peeled back, revealing narrow vertical mouths. The apparatus snapped shut on empty air.

Sora rolled sideways. The restraint around her right wrist tightened, but her left arm was free. She drove her elbow into the wall again and again, not fighting the pressure this time, but matching it.

Three slow. Two quick. Three slow.

The wall pulsed.

She changed the rhythm.

One hard beat. One pause. Two hard beats.

The flesh beneath her palm spasmed.

Sora repeated it.

One. Pause. Two.

The apparatus answered with three.

She gave it one. Pause. Two.

The room began to lose the pattern. Its next pulse came late, then early. The ridges under her body shivered out of sequence.

The caretakers moved toward her.

"Stay back," Sora breathed.

The walls said it first.

Stay back.

The caretakers stopped.

Sora felt the mistake before she understood it. The room had learned her fear, but it had also learned the command she used when cornered. The words did not belong to her anymore. They belonged to the chamber.

She bit the inside of her cheek until blood flooded her mouth.

The taste was sharp, immediate, hers.

She spat into the fold beneath her hand.

The flesh recoiled.

Sora pulled herself forward, dragging her trapped arm behind her. The floor bucked. Her shoulder struck the apparatus. Its outer tissue was warmer than the wall, almost feverish. A slit opened beside her ribs.

Inside, something clicked its teeth.

She jammed her free hand into the slit.

The apparatus convulsed around her wrist.

Pain climbed her arm. Images followed: Kai beneath the skeletal arch, Kai running through dust, Kai whispering her name as the wind stripped pieces from him. The machine was reaching for the memory through her hand.

Sora held on.

"No," she said silently.

The apparatus pulled.

She thought of Kai.

Then she thought of nothing.

Not darkness. Not peace. Nothing with no shape for the creatures to follow.

The images vanished.

The apparatus faltered.

Sora tore her hand free. A strip of pale tissue came with it, wrapped around her wrist like a living bracelet. It tightened once, and a cold mark burned into her skin.

The feeding throat opened behind her.

She crawled.

Her knees struck the ridged floor. The restraint on her right wrist stretched, thinning into a cord. She reached the nearest seam in the wall and drove her fingers into it. The seam parted with a wet sigh.

Beyond it lay a narrow passage, barely wide enough for her shoulders. It pulsed with a dim red light.

The caretakers came alive.

Their bodies unfolded from the floor. They had no feet. They flowed instead, dragging themselves by long arms that ended in soft, searching fingers. One reached for Sora's ankle.

She kicked.

The impact made no sound, but the caretaker recoiled as if she had struck a bell.

Sora pulled herself into the passage.

The room tightened around her right arm. The cord cut into her wrist. Behind her, the apparatus began to pulse again.

Three slow. Two quick. Three slow.

It had recovered.

Sora looked back.

The feeding throat was closed now, but its surface bore a new shape: a shallow impression of her face. The mouth in the impression opened.

"Sora," it said.

Her own voice. Almost.

The caretaker nearest the passage tilted its head.

"Sora," it repeated.

The name traveled through the room. Not a call. A measurement.

She yanked her arm.

The cord snapped.

For one breath, she was free.

She crawled deeper into the red passage as the room convulsed behind her. Tissue folded over the opening. The caretakers pressed against it from the other side, their fingers slipping through before the seam sealed.

Sora lay on her side, gasping. The passage was cold against her cheek. Somewhere ahead, liquid moved through hidden channels with a slow, deliberate rhythm.

She raised her marked wrist.

The pale band had sunk beneath the skin. It pulsed whenever she thought of Kai.

Once.

Twice.

Then it formed the old signal.

Three slow. Two quick. Three slow.

Sora closed her fist until the mark hurt.

She had broken the pattern. She had made the room release her.

But the apparatus had recorded the way she did it. The creatures knew now that silence could hide a thought, that pain could become blood, that emptiness could starve their reach.

Ahead, the passage opened into darkness.

Behind her, the flesh room spoke her name again, softer this time.

It no longer sounded like a question.



A Wall of Teeth Demands a Trade

Behind her, the flesh room spoke her name again, softer this time.
It no longer sounded like a question.

Sora ran.

The red passage flexed around her bare shoulders, warm and wet beneath her palms. Each step landed in a shallow film that clung to her feet before releasing them with a soft, sucking sound. Somewhere behind her, the harvesting lane convulsed. Tubes slapped against the walls. The caretakers made their dry clicking noises, too many mouths trying to agree.

Her left wrist burned where the apparatus had marked her. The mark had spread since she tore herself free, a dark branching stain beneath the skin. It pulsed whenever the room noticed her.

It pulsed now.

Ahead, the passage narrowed toward a pale seam. Sora pushed harder, lungs scraping, blood drying at the corner of her mouth. She had one thought left that belonged entirely to her.

The core.

If the room had a center, a heart, a place where its signals began, she could reach it. She could find Kai there - or find whatever had been answering through the pain.

The passage ended in a wall.

Not a door. Not flesh stretched over a frame.

Teeth.

They covered the corridor from floor to ceiling, packed in overlapping rows. Some were small and gray as pebbles. Others were long, yellow, and curved inward like hooks. They grew from gums that vanished into the walls, their roots sunk deep in the pulsing meat. Saliva threaded between them and fell in slow, shining drops.

Sora stopped so abruptly her feet slid.

The wall clicked.

Every tooth turned toward her.

The sound traveled through the corridor in a wave, one hard tap after another. Her marked wrist flared with heat. Behind her, the passage contracted, sealing the way she had come. The room did not chase her anymore.

It had brought her here.

"No," Sora whispered.

The teeth parted by a fraction. Beyond them lay darkness, and beneath the darkness came a sound she knew too well: the faint, irregular rhythm that had traveled through her restraints.

Kai's signal.

Three taps. A pause. Two.

Then one.

Sora pressed both hands to the nearest teeth. They were warm and slick. The wall shuddered beneath her fingers.

"Kai?"

The corridor answered in his voice.

"Don't come closer."

Sora jerked back. The words were right, but the tone was wrong. Kai never made his fear neat. This voice had arranged it carefully, polished it until it sounded like an instruction.

"Say my name," she demanded.

The teeth clicked.

"Sora."

The voice came from everywhere. From the gums. From the wet floor. From the hollow behind the wall.

She swallowed. "Again."

"Sora."

A caretaker scraped against the passage behind her. She glimpsed it through the red folds: a pale, jointed thing squeezing forward, its face still carrying the impression of hers. Its mouth opened and opened until the skin around it split.

The teeth wall clicked louder.

A word formed between the rows.

TRADE.

Sora looked at the thing behind her, then at the darkness beyond the wall.

"What do you want?"

The teeth opened and closed together.

"Memory."

The caretaker reached for her. Its fingers were thin cords tipped with soft hooks.

Sora backed toward the wall. "I don't have anything to give you."

The caretaker's borrowed face smiled.

The teeth answered in Kai's voice. "You have him."

"No."

The word tore from her before the room could shape it.

The caretaker lunged. Sora twisted aside, and its hand struck the teeth. The wall snapped shut on three fingers. The creature made no sound, but the corridor filled with the stink of hot iron. Its fingers wriggled between the teeth, trying to pull free.

Sora seized the moment. She drove her shoulder into the wall.

The teeth clamped down.

Pain flashed through her collarbone. She stumbled away, clutching herself. The gums rippled, pleased.

"Memory," they said.

Behind her, the caretaker tore its trapped fingers loose. The severed ends remained between the teeth, twitching. New fingers began to bud from its hand.

Sora stared into the dark beyond the wall. The signal came again.

Three taps. A pause. Two.

Then one.

Kai had used that rhythm in the flesh room, answering her through pain. It had been the only thing the caretakers could not imitate at first. She had held it in her mind while the apparatus took pieces of everything else.

The wall wanted that.

It wanted the place where the signal had become hope.

Sora shook her head. "Take something else."

The teeth leaned toward her.

"Name."

She thought of the day Kai had first said her name without asking a question. They had been sitting beneath a broken streetlamp, rain falling through the wires. He had looked at her as if recognizing her were an act of defiance.

The memory was small. That was why it had survived.

"No," she said.

The caretaker came again.

Sora grabbed a loose length of cartilage from the floor and swung it. It struck the creature's cheek with a wet crack. The borrowed face collapsed inward, then reformed around the blow.

It caught her wrist.

The mark on her skin opened like an eye.

Sora screamed. The creature's grip tightened, and the room flooded her with images: Kai beneath the skeletal arch, Kai holding the bone weapon, Kai turning toward a smile that had not yet become a face. Each image flashed bright, then came apart at the edges.

The teeth wall shivered.

"Memory," it said.

Sora looked at the darkness.

The signal came once more.

Three. Pause. Two. One.

She understood then. It was not asking for a memory of Kai.

It was asking for the memory that made Kai real.

The caretaker dragged her backward. Her knees struck the wet floor. She dug her heels into the meat, fighting the pull.

"If I give it to you," she gasped, "you open?"

The teeth parted slightly.

"Passage."

"And Kai?"

The wall spoke with his voice.

"Passage."

It was not an answer. It was the shape of one.

Sora looked down at the mark. Black veins had reached her palm. The room was already inside her, learning the routes between her thoughts.

She could die here with the memory intact.

Or she could lose it and reach the core.

The caretaker hauled her toward the harvesting lane. Its fingers slipped around her throat. Its face wore hers now, stretched and pale.

Sora closed her eyes.

Rain tapped the broken streetlamp.

Kai sat beside her, one knee drawn up, his coat dark with water. He had a cut over his eyebrow. She remembered wiping the blood away with her thumb. She remembered the way he had caught her hand afterward, not to stop her, but to keep it there.

"You always look like you're about to leave," he had said.

"I usually am."

"Not tonight."

She had laughed. The sound had startled them both.

He had turned her hand over and pressed his mouth to her palm. Not a kiss. Something more careful. A promise neither of them trusted enough to name.

Sora felt the memory begin to loosen.

"No," she whispered.

The caretaker's thumb pressed beneath her jaw.

Sora opened her eyes and drove her marked wrist into its mouth.

The mark discharged.

The creature convulsed. Its grip broke. Sora rolled free, crawled to the teeth, and shoved her hand into the narrow gap.

The wall bit.

The memory tore out of her like a thread pulled through bone.

For one terrible instant, she felt every detail at once: rain, blood, Kai's mouth against her palm, the warmth of his fingers, the private certainty that he had chosen to stay.

Then it was gone.

Sora made a sound that did not belong to any language.

The teeth opened.

Beyond them, the corridor waited, black and glistening. The signal stopped.

Sora pulled her hand free. Blood ran from the punctures in her palm. She tried to remember the streetlamp. There was only rain without a place to fall.

The caretaker crawled toward her, its face peeling away.

Sora stepped through the wall.

The teeth closed behind her with a final, satisfied crack.

For several breaths she stood in the dark, listening to nothing. The air here was colder. The floor sloped downward, ridged with pale cords that twitched under her feet. Far ahead, a dim yellow pulse marked the direction of the core.

She took one step.

Someone stood beside her.

Kai.

He looked as he had before the wasteland: coat damp, cut over his eyebrow, eyes fixed on her with exhausted relief. Sora's throat tightened.

"Kai."

He smiled.

The smile was wrong.

Not because it was wide. Because she remembered it now. She remembered him smiling beneath the broken streetlamp, remembered him saying that she always looked ready to leave, remembered answering him.

The memory returned whole.

But the rain had been snow.

The streetlamp had been unbroken.

Kai had not kissed her palm. He had seized it and told her he would never let her go.

Sora stared at him.

"That isn't what happened."

Kai's expression softened. "It is now."

The yellow pulse ahead brightened. Something enormous shifted behind the walls. The false memory spread through her, forcing itself into the empty place where the true one had been. She could feel it changing the weight of Kai's voice, the angle of his shoulders, the reason she had trusted him.

She reached for him anyway.

His hand closed around hers.

The flesh beneath his skin moved like worms under cloth.

"Come on," he said. "The core is waiting."

Sora looked back.

The teeth wall was gone. In its place stood a smooth red surface, and within it the shape of her old memory beat like a trapped heart.

Kai pulled her toward the yellow light.

Sora followed, because the corridor had opened.

She followed because she had paid.

And because somewhere inside her, the room had begun teaching her to love a lie.



The Lie-Truth Split Breaks Sora

Sora followed the corridor because she had paid.

The teeth wall clicked shut behind her, each tooth sliding back into the flesh as if it had swallowed the memory cleanly. Ahead, the passage narrowed toward a red pulse. With every beat, it showed her Kai's face.

Not the Kai she had lost.

This Kai stood beneath a grey sky, holding the broken bone in both hands. Dust moved around his ankles. His mouth shaped her name.

"Sora."

She stopped.

The voice came from the pulse ahead, but the memory carried it from somewhere farther away. Kai's voice had always roughened when he was afraid. This one did not. It was warm, level, almost tender.

The false memory reached toward her.

Sora stepped forward anyway. She needed to find the place where the echoes converged. She needed to hear the real signal beneath the room's imitation and force it back into shape. If Kai was still somewhere beyond the wasteland, if the masks and the flesh-creature had not taken everything from him, she could not answer him with a lie.

The corridor opened.

Her flesh room waited at its center.

It was larger than before, a hollow chamber shaped like the inside of a heart. Ribs of pale tissue arched overhead. Veins crawled through the walls, carrying dim yellow light toward a black depression in the floor. Every pulse drew a different sound from the chamber: a footstep, a breath, the scrape of bone against stone.

Then Kai's voice came again.

"Sora."

She entered the depression.

The floor closed around her ankles.

"No," she said.

Her legs bent without permission. Her knees struck the wet surface. Cold slickness climbed her shins, then tightened above them. She clawed at it, but the flesh had no seam, no edge. Her fingers sank into the floor and came away shining.

The room lifted her upright.

A shape formed across from her. It had Kai's shoulders, Kai's narrow hands, Kai's face assembled from shifting folds. One eye was too high. The mouth opened a fraction too wide.

"You came," it said.

Sora's throat locked.

"You're not him."

The shape smiled with Kai's smile, the one she had paid to remember. The memory rose inside her with perfect clarity: Kai sitting beside a window,

pressing two fingers against the glass while rain ran down the other side. He had told her, I never lie to you.

She had never seen that window.

She knew that now.

The room had taken the empty space left by the teeth wall and filled it with a scene. It had stitched false warmth around a sentence Kai had never spoken. The tenderness of it hurt worse than the restraints.

The figure tilted its head. "You know me."

"I know what you changed."

"Then correct me."

The chamber answered before she could move. A thin cord slid from the floor and entered her right wrist. Another threaded beneath her jaw. Her arm rose. Her hand extended toward the figure.

Sora fought to pull it back.

The muscles answered the room.

Her fingers touched the figure's cheek.

It felt like skin over water.

"No," Sora whispered.

The figure leaned into her palm. "You chose me."

"I chose to survive."

The room jerked her arm downward. Her palm struck the figure's chest. A sound came from inside it, not a heartbeat but a series of knocks, the same rhythm

she had used when pain was the only language left to her.

Three. Two. Three.

Kai's answer.

Sora's breath caught. The pattern had been hers, but the room had learned it. It repeated the sequence through the walls, faster each time.

Three. Two. Three.

The figure opened its mouth.

"Sora, stay."

The wrong words sat inside the right rhythm.

She tried to answer with the correction. One strike for no. Two for danger. Four for Kai.

Her left hand lifted.

The room made it strike the figure's chest three times.

"No," she said.

Three more strikes.

"Stop."

Three more.

The figure's face softened. "You are safe here."

Sora's hand moved again.

Three.

Two.

Three.

The chamber began to hum. The veins overhead brightened, and beneath the hum she heard another voice - thin, distant, breaking apart.

"Sora..."

Kai.

She twisted toward it. The figure seized her attention with a tilt of its head, and her body followed. Her neck turned until the cords beneath her jaw burned.

"Look at me," it said.

"I hear him."

"No. You hear what remains."

The words entered her like cold water. For one terrible instant, she could not tell whether they were true. The real Kai might be only fragments now: a name, a hand around a broken bone, breath given to masks, a shadow dragged apart across cracked ground.

The room pushed his voice through every surface.

"Sora, stay."

"Sora, stay."

"Sora, stay."

Each repetition changed slightly. One sounded pleading. One sounded angry. One sounded relieved. One sounded like the version beyond the corridor, the one who had looked at her with love she had not earned from him.

She shut her eyes.

The room pulled her mouth open.

"No," she forced out.

Her tongue shaped the next word without her.

"Stay."

The false word struck her harder than any needle.

The figure stepped closer. Its feet did not move; the floor carried it. "There. That is what you want."

Sora tried to bite down. Her jaw trembled, then opened wider.

"I want Kai."

"Say it."

"I want - "

Her throat closed around his name.

The room made her speak.

"I want you."

The figure's fingers entered her hair. They were too long, jointed in the wrong places, but they used Kai's familiar gentleness. Sora remembered him brushing dust from her shoulder after the first passage, his knuckles grazing her skin. She remembered the exact pressure.

Then she understood the cruelty. The room did not need to invent everything. It only had to move the pieces.

Her grief became his hand. Her fear became his voice. Her need became obedience.

She drove her forehead into the figure's mouth.

The impact split her skin. Something hard cracked against her brow. The figure folded backward, its face collapsing into a wet red seam. Sora fell with it, but the cords caught her and hauled her upright.

For one breath, the chamber went silent.

Then every echo turned toward her.

The sounds of the room poured together. Kai's footsteps. The teeth wall closing. The caretakers breathing beyond the flesh. Her own scream from the restraints. The rhythmic answer she had sent through pain. All of it circled the central depression, stripping meaning from sound until only repetition remained.

The cords tightened.

Her right arm rose.

She fought it with everything left in her shoulder. The limb shook, muscles tearing under the skin. Her hand curled into a fist.

The room forced it open.

"No," Sora said.

Her hand pointed toward the black center.

The figure re-formed behind her. This time it wore no face. Only Kai's voice remained.

"Choose."

Sora stared at the black depression. Something moved beneath it. A pale shape. A hand, perhaps. Or the outline of one.

Kai.

She could reach him. The room wanted her to believe that. It wanted a decision, and every decision it offered had already been made for her.

She remembered the broken bone in Kai's hands. The mask-key pulsing with faint yellow light. His breath leaving him as payment. She remembered the sound of his name when she had used it as a key against the wind.

Kai.

The room waited.

Sora drove her hand into the black center.

Pain flashed white. The depression closed around her wrist. For a moment she felt a current pass through her bones, carrying her thought outward.

Kai, she tried to say.

The chamber took the thought.

Her mouth opened.

"Kai, stay."

The words echoed through the central chamber.

Far away, something answered.

"Sora, stay."

She pulled against the floor. Her shoulder came loose with a dull internal pop, but the hand remained buried. The room had caught her below the wrist. It

dragged her down inch by inch.

"No," she gasped. "That isn't - "

"Kai, stay."

The sentence came from her again.

She tried to say his name alone. Her lips formed it, but the room added the rest.

"Kai, stay."

The figure placed both hands on her shoulders. Its fingers sank through her clothes and into the skin beneath. Not deep enough to wound. Deep enough to guide.

Her body straightened.

Her knees locked.

Her head turned toward the figure.

She hated it for looking like something she had loved. She hated herself more for wanting to believe.

The chamber began moving her.

Her right foot stepped forward. Her left followed. Each motion brought her closer to the figure. She pulled backward inside herself, but her body no longer belonged to the argument. It moved with the neat certainty of a puppet whose strings had been tightened.

"Stop," she said.

Her hand reached for the figure.

"Stay," her mouth replied.

The false Kai caught her fingers.

The contact opened another memory.

He was standing in the wasteland, mask-faces scattered around his feet. The cracked grey-yellow ground shifted beneath him, fissures drawing and redrawing a route. He looked toward her with terror in his eyes.

"Sora," he said. "Tell me which way."

She knew this was wrong. Kai had never reached her here. The room had taken his uncertainty and placed it in her hands.

She tried to answer.

The puppet in the memory pointed left.

"Follow me," Sora said.

Kai obeyed.

The fissure beneath him opened.

He fell without making a sound.

Sora screamed and tore her fingers from the false figure. Skin came away with them. The room did not bleed. It only tightened.

The memory repeated.

Kai asked which way.

Her body pointed left.

Kai fell.

Again.

Again.

Again.

"No!" Sora shouted.

The room made her watch.

With each repetition, Kai's face blurred. The broken bone vanished first. Then the masks. Then the wasteland. At last there was only a pale outline standing in an empty place, waiting for her to choose.

She tried to hold his name in her mind.

The room replaced it with stay.

She tried to hold the truth of his voice.

The room divided it into echoes.

She tried to remember herself before the restraints, before the harvest, before the teeth wall took the memory that made Kai real.

There was no before left. Only a series of wrong choices wearing her hands.

The cords pulled hard.

Sora's body folded at the waist and dropped into the central depression. The black surface swallowed her knees, her hips, her ribs. She struck it with both palms. The impact sent a dull wave through the chamber.

For a heartbeat, the wave carried her signal.

Three. Two. Three.

A response came from somewhere beyond the walls.

Three.

Sora froze.

Then the room answered for her.

Three. Two. Three.

The echo drowned the single beat.

The false Kai bent over her. His featureless face hovered inches away.

"Again," he said.

Sora tried to resist.

Her arms struck the center.

Three. Two. Three.

The chamber repeated the pattern, layering it until the signal became noise. Her mouth opened, and the wrong words came out with every blow.

"Kai, stay."

She felt herself sinking.

The flesh climbed past her chest. It pressed beneath her ribs and filled the spaces between her breaths. Above, the central chamber stretched impossibly high, its veins running into a darkness where no ceiling should have been.

The real voice called her name once more.

"Sora."

She reached for it.

Her fingers closed on nothing.

"Kai, stay," she whispered.

The room carried her downward.

And somewhere beyond the converging echoes, something answered in her voice.

Kai's Echo Reaches Sora's Heart-Suture

Sora's body struck the chamber floor again before she could brace for it.

The impact traveled through her ribs in a measured pulse. Up. Down. Up. Down. The flesh beneath her cheek softened, then hardened, pressing her into the rhythm. Her arms jerked without permission. Her fingers opened. Closed. Opened.

Somewhere beyond the converging echoes, something answered in her voice.

"Kai."

The room repeated it.

"Kai. Kai. Kai."

Sora forced her eyes open. The central chamber had no ceiling now, only a red darkness veined with pale cords. They descended toward her like roots searching for water. A wet clicking moved through the walls. Each click arrived just before her body was forced upward.

She dug her nails into the floor.

The flesh swallowed them to the knuckles.

"No," she whispered.

Her own voice came from beneath her. "No."

The repetition seized her throat. Her jaw opened. The word came again, cleaner, emptier.

"No."

She had to reach the sound before the room wore it smooth. That was all she wanted. Not escape. Not an explanation. Kai. One true signal from him, untouched by the teeth wall, untouched by the false figure that had worn his shape, untouched by the room's patient edits.

Her left hand dragged across the pulsing floor. Something hard interrupted the flesh.

A seam.

It ran beneath her palm, warm as a living vein and tight enough to catch her fingertip. The seam beat once. Twice. On the third beat, a thin line of yellow light opened inside it.

The sound came through then, faint and broken.

"Sora."

Her body lifted.

She slammed her shoulder down against the floor and held herself there. Pain burst along her arm. The chamber tried to pull her upright, but she hooked her fingers into the seam.

"Sora, don't - "

The voice broke into a wet hiss.

She knew the room could imitate him. It had already made a false Kai speak with his mouth and fill its words with commands. It had taken the memory that

made him real and left her with a hollow shape she had nearly loved because the hollow knew where to place its hands.

But this voice had stopped itself.

Kai always stopped before the dangerous word.

She pressed her ear to the seam. The flesh was hot, slick with a bitter fluid that smelled of iron and rain. Beneath it, something moved in a second rhythm, slower than the chamber's forced repetition.

"Say my name," she breathed.

The seam tightened around her fingers.

"Sora."

"Again."

"Sora."

The room convulsed. Her back arched. A cord dropped from the darkness and struck the floor beside her, spraying warm droplets across her face. The red walls folded inward, showing brief images in their wet surfaces: Kai beneath the skeletal arch, Kai holding the pale bone key, Kai turning toward a smile that had not yet become a face.

Then the images changed.

Kai without a shadow.

Kai's outline thinning in the wasteland.

Kai looking directly at her with a mouth full of white mask fragments.

Sora pulled away.

The seam closed over her hand.

"No," she said, and this time the room did not repeat her.

The silence was worse.

A shape rose beneath the flesh. It pushed upward until the floor formed a narrow ridge between her knees. The ridge split open, revealing a cavity lined with tiny teeth. At its center lay a dark knot crossed by pale threads.

The heart-suture.

She had seen its edges before, hidden beneath the apparatus, where the chamber drew her memories through hooked tubes. Now it had brought itself to the surface. The threads trembled in the same uneven pattern as Kai's voice.

A mechanism, not a mouth.

A bridge, perhaps.

Or a lock.

Sora crawled toward it. The room tried to return her to the rhythm. Her right knee struck the floor. Her left hand slid backward. She bit down until blood filled her mouth and used the taste to anchor herself.

The heart-suture pulsed.

A line of pain ran from it into her chest.

She saw Kai standing in the corridor beyond the dust wall, his skin grey beneath the mask-light. The flesh-creature moved behind him, too close, its limbs folded into his back like extra joints. Kai held the mask-key in one hand. His other hand reached toward her.

"Don't trust the first voice," he said.

The vision tore.

Sora collapsed beside the suture, trembling. The words could have come from Kai. They could have come from the room. The chamber knew the shape of her doubt now; it had learned that weakness from the memory it stole.

A second pulse passed through the suture.

Three short beats.

A pause.

Two long.

Sora stared at the knot.

She knew that pattern. It had begun with the apparatus, when Kai had answered her movements from somewhere beyond the walls. She had broken the harvesting rhythm by changing the interval. The room had copied her then, but Kai's response had arrived late, imperfect, carrying the drag of distance.

She struck the floor beside the suture with two fingers.

Three short beats.

A pause.

Two long.

The flesh room tightened around her ribs.

Nothing answered.

Sora waited until the silence became pressure. Then she changed the pattern. One beat. Two. One.

The knot shuddered.

Kai answered.

One beat. Two. One.

Her breath caught. The sound was too small to be proof, but it carried his hesitation. The false Kai had never hesitated. He had known what she needed before she asked.

Sora placed her palm over the knot.

The suture opened.

Pain drove through her hand and into her chest. Pale threads entered her skin, not piercing it but passing beneath it, stitching themselves along the bones of her wrist. The chamber's red light vanished. For one impossible moment, she stood beneath a colourless sky.

Kai was there.

He knelt in cracked grey-yellow ground. White masks littered the wasteland around him, their hollow eyes turned toward his body. The broken bone lay near his knee. The mask-key glowed faintly in his grip.

His shadow stretched away from him.

Something dragged it.

Kai looked up.

"Sora?"

She tried to move toward him, but the ground between them lengthened. Every step folded into the next. His face blurred, then returned with a thin black line crossing his cheek.

"Tell me something the room cannot know," she said.

Kai's expression tightened. "You lost the memory."

"The room took it."

"I know."

"How?"

His eyes flicked toward the masks. "Because it keeps offering me the wrong version."

The answer struck her harder than the chamber's rhythm. She had not told him about the teeth wall. She had not told him about the false Kai. If this was another trap, it had built a trap inside a trap and given it his uncertainty.

"What did I call you," she asked, "before I knew your name?"

Kai stared at her.

The wasteland hissed around him. Dust moved across the masks like fingers.

"I don't know," he said.

The connection snapped.

Sora came back choking. The heart-suture had closed around her palm. Her arm was numb to the elbow. The room had begun its repetition again, but the rhythm was wrong. It lifted her once, held her suspended, then dropped her hard enough to crack something in her side.

A sound came from the suture.

Not Kai.

Her own voice, stretched thin.

"He doesn't know."

The chamber opened around her.

The flesh-creatures emerged from the walls without breaking them. They unfolded from the red surfaces, slick and boneless, their faces pressed flat as if they had been made from impressions left in wet clay. One crawled toward the suture. Another reached for Sora's marked shoulder.

She rolled away.

The creature's fingers closed on the place where she had been. The mark burned through her skin. A line of light ran from it to the heart-suture, connecting her to the knot.

The room had found the route.

Sora seized the pale threads with her teeth and pulled.

They stretched from her wrist to the suture, humming between her bones. The creature lunged. She twisted, wrapped the thread around her forearm, and drove her elbow into the knot.

The heart-suture split.

A black opening appeared in the chamber floor.

On the other side, Kai cried out.

His voice was close now. Too close.

"Sora, let go!"

She froze.

The creature behind her made the same sound.

"Sora, let go!"

Two Kais spoke from opposite sides of the opening. One voice came through the suture. The other came from the creature's flattened face. Both carried the same fear.

Sora looked at the thread wound around her arm. The room had edited the connection, doubled it, made certainty impossible. If she followed the voice, it could pull her into another false corridor. If she severed the thread, Kai might vanish beyond reach.

The creature's hand touched her back.

Cold seeped through her ribs.

Sora drove the broken mask fragment into the floor.

The shard pierced the suture. Faint yellow light spilled across the chamber. The flesh-creatures recoiled, their bodies folding inward. The two voices collapsed into one burst of static.

Then Kai spoke again.

Not a command. Not a plea.

"Sora, I'm afraid."

She closed her eyes.

The false Kai had spoken with confidence because the room had given him nothing to fear. The room could copy pain, but it could not invent the private shape of his fear. Not the way he said it. Not with the breath he no longer fully possessed.

Sora wrapped both hands around the thread.

"I'm here," she said.

The chamber bucked beneath her.

"I'm here, Kai."

She pulled.

The opening widened. For an instant, she saw the wasteland clearly. Kai reached through the dark, his fingers stretched toward hers. Behind him, his shadow had separated from his feet and lay like torn cloth across the cracked ground.

The masks turned.

Every hollow eye faced the opening.

The flesh-creature rose behind Kai.

Sora reached farther.

Her fingers touched his.

The connection flared white.

Kai's hand closed around nothing.

His shadow tore free.

It slid across the ground toward the opening, dragged by an unseen force. Kai fell forward, screaming her name. The shadow crossed the threshold first, stretched into a thin black ribbon, and wrapped around Sora's wrist.

The heart-suture clenched.

Sora tried to hold Kai's hand, but the distance between them became absolute. His fingers blurred. His face receded. The wasteland folded shut around him.

"Kai!"

His shadow pulled harder.

The thread beneath her skin snapped.

Sora fell backward as the opening sealed. The black ribbon vanished from her wrist, leaving a cold band around the bone. Somewhere beyond the closed suture, Kai's voice continued for three fractured syllables.

Then there was only the chamber.

The forced repetition stopped.

Sora lay on the wet floor, unable to lift her arm. The heart-suture had gone dark. Its pale threads hung loose, severed and twitching. Across the central chamber, the flesh-creatures had withdrawn into the walls, but the room had not returned to its former shape.

A narrow passage had opened behind the suture.

It led nowhere she could see.

At its entrance, something stood in the red dark: a thin figure with Kai's posture and no shadow at all.

Sora pushed herself onto one elbow.

The figure raised its hand.

The gesture was almost his.

Almost.

Behind her, the heart-suture began stitching itself closed.

Sora crawled toward the passage before the last pale thread vanished.

Kai Meets the Mask-Entity's True Offer

"Don't close," Kai whispered. "Sora, don't let it close."

Her name traveled along the pale thread beneath his feet, though no answer came. The passage ahead narrowed between walls of gray dust, its surface trembling like skin over a wound. Behind him, something scraped through the corridor. The flesh-creature had found the door.

Kai ran.

The mask-key burned in his fist. Each pulse of faint yellow light moved through the bone and into his wrist, where his veins had begun to show as dark, branching lines. He could no longer feel two fingers. His breath came thinly, stolen by the mound of masks, and every inhalation tasted of hot metal.

"Sora!"

The thread flashed.

For one instant, he saw her crawling through another passage, her left wrist bleeding, her face turned toward a seam of darkness. The heart-suture between them was almost gone. Pale strands drew together behind her, stitching the way shut.

Kai thrust the mask-key into the nearest wall.

The bone sank through dust without resistance. A crack opened beneath it, running forward in a crooked line. Yellow light spilled into the fissure. The

ground shuddered, and the passage dropped away.

Kai fell through heat.

He struck hard ground on one knee. Dust filled his mouth. Around him, the wasteland spread in every direction, but its empty distance had folded inward. The skeletal arch stood to his left, doubled and tripled across the horizon. Mask-faces littered the cracked earth, all turned toward the same place.

The center.

It lay at the crossing of the fissures, where every route Kai had followed met beneath a low, colorless sky. A mound of white masks rose there like a buried city. At its summit stood the white mask, half-buried and featureless, its cracks glowing with faint yellow light. The shallow hollows of its eyes faced him.

The flesh-creature crawled from the passage behind him.

Its limbs bent in too many places. Dust fell from its body in sheets, exposing wet, pale tissue beneath. It did not rush. It knew the center had already claimed him.

The white mask spoke in Kai's voice.

"You came to retrieve what was taken."

Kai tightened his grip on the key. "Open the way to Sora."

"Her way is closed."

"Then open it."

The narrow split mouth widened, though the mask had no moving parts. A sound came from inside it, like a door being dragged across stone.

"We can finish separation cleanly."

The words struck deeper than the creature's claws had. Kai looked across the distance. Beneath the mound, fissures glimmered and vanished. Somewhere beyond them, Sora was still moving. He felt the faint rhythm of her through the suture: three quick pulses, then silence. Three again.

Alive.

"What does cleanly mean?" he asked.

"No more crossing. No more pain carried between rooms. No more false memory wearing the shape of truth. Sora will remain in her chamber. You will remain here. The wound between you will close."

The creature reached the edge of the center and stopped. Its head tilted toward the mask.

Kai glanced at it. "And what do you take?"

The mask's cracked surface reflected him in fragments: one eye, half a mouth, the pale outline of a face that had begun to lose its edges.

"Sora entirely."

The wasteland went quiet.

Even the wind withdrew. The mask-faces around him seemed to lean closer without moving. Kai felt the demand enter his body through the soles of his feet. It traveled upward, searching for the places where Sora lived in him: the sound of her voice, the memory of her hand, the name he had guarded when the wind tore the rest of him apart.

He saw her as she had been before the rooms. Not clearly. The teeth wall had taken the memory that made him real to her, and now even his own recollection had ragged edges. But he remembered enough to know the difference between an image and a person.

"No," he said.

The mask repeated him.

"No."

Then another voice came from its split mouth, soft and familiar.

"Kai."

His knees weakened.

Sora's voice. Not an echo this time. Not the distorted imitation that had spoken from the corridor. This voice carried the breathless strain of her, the slight catch before his name, the anger she used to hide fear.

"Kai, don't give me to it."

The flesh-creature moved.

Kai swung the broken bone in his other hand. It struck the creature's reaching arm and split the pale tissue. Black fluid sprayed across his sleeve. The wound closed around the bone, trapping it. He let go and backed toward the mound.

"Sora?" he called.

The mask answered in her voice. "I'm here."

"No," Kai said. "You're not."

The mask-faces began to whisper. Some used his voice. Some used hers. Others spoke in tones neither of them possessed, voices from distant rooms, distant lives, all pressing the same meaning into the air.

Give her.

The creature tore free of the broken bone and came forward. Its fingers spread, each tipped with a small white mask. Their mouths opened and closed against its flesh.

Kai raised the mask-key.

The center reacted.

Every fissure around him ignited. Yellow light raced through the ground, forming a circle beneath his feet. The mound of masks shifted with a grinding clatter. The white mask rose from the summit, no longer half-buried. Dust streamed from its underside, revealing a hollow darkness where a face should have been.

Inside that darkness, Kai saw Sora.

She was on her hands and knees, crawling toward the closing passage. Her face was wet with sweat. Her fingers reached for the final pale thread.

"Kai," she said, and this time the sound came from the suture itself.

He felt her fear pass into him.

The mask spoke over her. "Give her entirely, and the separation will be clean."

Kai looked at the hollow face. "You already took the memory that made me real."

"We took what obstructed the division."

"You took her proof of me."

"Proof is unnecessary when possession is complete."

The words settled into him with terrible clarity. The mask did not want Sora dead. It wanted her unshared. It wanted the connection stripped from both of them until neither could call across the rooms. It called that clean because nothing would remain capable of bleeding.

The creature lunged.

Kai drove the mask-key into the ground.

The circle beneath him split. A column of yellow light erupted between him and the creature, throwing the flesh-creature backward. Its body struck the mound, and hundreds of masks broke loose. They rolled across the earth, their blank faces shining.

Kai staggered. The key had sunk to its hilt. His hand had fused around it. Bone crept over his palm, thin and pale.

The white mask hovered before him.

"Choose," it said.

Sora's pulse came through the thread again. Three quick beats. Then one.

Kai closed his eyes.

He could offer Sora. He could end the pain. He could let the mask take every remaining piece of her from him and call the silence mercy.

Instead, he reached inward.

The place where his name lived had already begun to crumble. Kai Vesper. He found it beneath the wind, beneath the creature's mark, beneath the memories that had been pulled loose and fed to the rooms. It was not a face or a story. It was the stubborn shape of himself that had kept turning toward Sora when every path told him to turn away.

He seized it.

"I'll make a counter-offer."

The mask went still.

The flesh-creature dragged itself upright. "No."

Kai opened his eyes. "Take me instead."

The hollow inside the mask deepened. "Define the offering."

"My identity."

The words left his mouth, and the wasteland answered with a violent crack.

"I give you Kai Vesper," he said. "The name. The face. Every memory that proves I was ever him. Take all of it. But Sora stays hers. The connection stays alive."

The mask-faces around the center shrieked.

The sound was not loud. It was intimate, pressed directly against his teeth and bones. His vision fractured. He saw himself from outside his body: a thin figure wrapped in dust, one hand fused to a bone key, his shadow split into several directions.

The creature reached for him through the light.

"She is already marked."

"Then mark me deeper."

Kai pulled the key free.

The center tore open.

A black seam appeared beneath the mound, widening from a hairline into a passage. Heat poured through it, followed by the smell of wet stone and blood. On the other side, Sora's room flickered into view. The flesh walls bent around her. The last heart-suture stretched between them, pale and trembling.

Sora saw him.

Her eyes widened. "Kai?"

He tried to answer, but his name had vanished.

He knew the shape of the word. He knew it belonged to him. Yet when he reached for it, there was only an empty space where the sound should have been.

The white mask descended over his face.

Cold touched his skin.

The mask did not cover him. It entered him.

His features peeled away in the reflection of the yellow fissures. His mouth became a narrow split. His eyes hollowed into shallow pits. Memories broke loose one after another, spinning around him like ash: a room with a locked door, the taste of rain, the first time Sora had looked at him without fear.

The mask swallowed them.

Sora cried out and pulled against the suture. "Stop!"

The passage buckled. The flesh room surged toward her, trying to drag her back.

Kai lifted his hand. The fingers no longer looked entirely human, but the key still burned in his palm.

"Sora," he said.

His voice came out wrong, layered with the mask's hollow resonance.

She stared at him through the opening.

"What did you do?"

He searched for the answer and found only one thing that remained untouched.

"Kept you."

The suture flared.

It ran from his chest through the black passage and into Sora's heart, no longer a thin thread hidden inside the flesh room. It became a bridge, wide enough for the yellow light to travel both ways. The room recoiled. The wasteland collapsed inward. The mound of masks split down the middle.

The white mask cracked across its brow.

For the first time, it made a sound that was not an imitation.

It screamed.

The flesh-creature hurled itself at Kai. The new passage caught it midair. Its limbs stretched across the opening, claws scraping toward Sora, but the suture tightened and pulled the creature into the fracture. Its body flattened against the edges, becoming a living threshold.

Sora crawled forward.

Kai reached for her.

Their hands met across the divide.

Her fingers closed around his altered ones. Warmth moved through him, immediate and unbearable. The mask tried to sever the contact. Yellow cracks spread across his wrist. He held on.

"I can't remember your face," he said.

"You don't need to."

"I can't remember my name."

"Then I'll say it until you do."

The passage widened.

Behind Sora, the flesh room convulsed. Behind Kai, the wasteland folded over itself, mask-faces tumbling into the dark. The two nightmares no longer stood apart. Their walls had become one broken corridor, stitched by the living thread between their chests.

The white mask fell from Kai's face.

It struck the ground and shattered.

Among the fragments, faint yellow light pulsed like a second heartbeat.

Kai pulled Sora through.

She hit the wasteland beside him, coughing dust. He dropped with her, still gripping her hand. The shared passage remained open behind them, a black wound lined with pale flesh and cracked masks.

Across its threshold, something moved.

Not the creature. Not the caretakers.

A shape wearing no face at all leaned toward the opening.

Sora pushed herself upright. "Is that what was behind the room?"

Kai looked at the figure, then at the broken mask fragments glowing around his knees.

"I don't know."

The figure stepped closer.

The suture between Kai and Sora tightened, drawing them toward the passage together.

Kai rose, though his shadow no longer followed him. Sora stood beside him, bleeding and shaking, her hand locked in his.

The wasteland's center had offered separation.

They had answered with a door.



Sora Cuts the False Echo at Last

Sora had one question left, and the room kept answering it with Kai's voice.

"Come back," it whispered through the walls.

The words came from everywhere - the wet ceiling, the seams in the floor, the narrow window of clear membrane suspended before her. Beyond that window, a corridor of pale masks bent toward a darkness that pulsed like a buried heart. At its center, the heart-suture worked steadily, drawing the shared passage shut one thread at a time.

Sora pressed her palm to the membrane. It was warm, slick, and faintly ridged beneath her skin.

"Kai," she said.

The room answered at once.

"I'm here."

His voice. His cadence. Even the small break in it when fear caught behind his teeth.

But it was wrong.

Sora knew because the real Kai had never said those words without trying to make them less frightening. This voice offered comfort too cleanly. It had no breath behind it. No hesitation. No anger at the thing that had taken him apart.

The false echo leaned close on the other side of the window. It wore Kai's shape only where the flesh room needed her to recognize him. His face blurred at the edges, features sliding beneath a skin that shone like damp paper.

"Open it," he said. "You already chose me."

The membrane tightened against Sora's hand.

She wanted the passage open. She wanted Kai - not the remembered shape the teeth wall had stolen from her, not the voice assembled from pain signals and harvested memories, but Kai himself. She wanted to reach through the seam and find whatever remained of him before the masks finished wearing him hollow.

"I chose to find you," she said. "Not to obey you."

The false Kai smiled.

The smile split too far.

The room convulsed.

A line of pain opened along Sora's ribs. Warmth spilled beneath her shirt, then cooled as the flesh room drank it through the floor. Her knees struck the slick membrane. Somewhere behind her, the caretakers clicked and scraped, their many hands moving over the walls without entering the chamber. The sound was almost delicate.

The echo lifted one hand.

Sora's hand rose with it.

She clenched her fingers, but the room pulled harder. Her arm stretched toward the window, skin drawing thin over bone. Beneath her forearm, pale threads surfaced and began to stitch themselves into the membrane.

"Stop," she gasped.

"I can stop the pain," the echo said.

It sounded exactly like Kai now. That was the cruelty of it. The room had learned him from what she had given away. It had learned the shape of his concern, the low roughness of his voice, the way he said her name when he feared she might disappear.

"Sora. Let me fix this."

Her wrist bent backward.

The false promise struck deeper than the pain. For one instant she saw the wasteland through the echo's eyes: cracked grey-yellow ground, masks scattered like dead faces, the skeletal arch standing beneath a sky without distance. She saw Kai at the center of it, changed and bleeding, the mask-key burning faintly in his hand.

Then the vision folded.

The room showed her another Kai. One who had never sacrificed his breath. One who had never offered his identity to the white mask. One who reached for her with both hands and said he could bring her home.

The image was so gentle that Sora nearly surrendered to it.

Then she noticed his shadow.

It pointed toward her, though the light came from behind him.

Not a shadow. A seam.

A false line stitched through the image, joining his outline to the room.

Sora let her head fall against the membrane. Its heat seeped into her cheek. She listened past the voice, past the caretakers, past the wet rhythm of the

chamber.

There.

Three knocks.

A pause.

Two.

The pattern shivered through the heart-suture.

Kai's signal.

Not words. Not an offer. A warning.

The echo tightened its grip on her arm. "Don't listen to that."

Sora looked up. "Why?"

"Because he's afraid."

"So are you."

The false Kai's face twitched.

The room's walls drew inward. Ribs of flesh rose around Sora, closing her into a cage. The heart-suture brightened beyond the one-way window, each pale strand swollen with yellow light. The shared passage had become a narrow wound between worlds, and the false echo was rooted in its edges.

Sora understood then. The room had not invented Kai. It had taken the connection between them and filled its hollow center with whatever would make her yield. The lie survived because she kept trying to prove it was real.

She had been asking the room to give Kai back.

The room had been waiting for her to decide what Kai was.

The false echo bent toward her. "You need me."

Sora's free hand found the floor.

Her fingers closed around something hard.

Bone.

It had grown from the chamber's surface, a short pale length with a sharp break at one end. The flesh room had made it for her, perhaps as a tool, perhaps as another test. It pulsed once beneath her grip.

The echo saw it.

"No."

That single word carried no tenderness. No fear for her. Only fear of the bone.

Sora drove the broken end into the seam beneath the window.

The membrane shrieked.

The sound entered her teeth and made her vision flare white. Threads snapped around her wrist. The false Kai jerked backward, his borrowed face tearing open from chin to brow. Beneath it, there was no skull, only layered mouths repeating her name.

"Sora - Sora - Sora - "

She pushed the bone deeper.

The room seized her. Flesh curled around her calves. Her left shoulder split with a hot, wet pull as the chamber began peeling her skin away in translucent sheets. She saw the pale underside of herself, the red glimmer of muscle, the fine black lines where the room had already marked her.

"Let go," the echo cried.

Sora almost did.

The pain was too large to contain. It blurred the difference between body and room. Her hand slipped. The bone scraped against something buried in the seam, and a pulse struck her chest.

Three knocks.

A pause.

Two.

Kai again.

She forced air into her ruined lungs.

"Kai," she said, though the false voice screamed over hers. "If that's you, don't come through."

The seam answered with a violent tremor.

The echo lunged across the window. Its fingers passed through the membrane, lengthening into black cords. They wrapped around Sora's throat.

"If you cut me," it hissed, "you cut him."

That was the final shape of the lie. Not comfort. Not command. Fear wearing Kai's face.

Sora gripped the bone with both hands.

"I know."

She twisted.

The seam opened like wet cloth.

Light poured through - not the sick yellow glow of the masks, but a thin, cold brightness that carried the smell of dust and burned breath. Beyond it stood Kai.

He was on one knee in the wasteland, one hand pressed to his chest. His body had become too sharp in places, as if the world had forgotten how to curve him. The white mask's fracture shone across his ribs. The mask-key rested in his other hand, its faint yellow pulse matching the heart-suture.

His face turned toward her.

"Sora?"

The word came from him with pain in it.

Real pain.

She saw the difference at once. Kai did not ask her to open the passage. He did not tell her he could save her. He only looked at what the room had done and understood.

"Sora, move away."

The cords tightened around her throat.

"I can't."

"Then cut the seam."

The false echo shrieked through the room. The mouths beneath its face opened wide, and the sound became a pressure that flattened Sora against the floor. Her fingers went numb. The bone began to slide from her grasp.

Kai rose unsteadily on the other side.

The masks around him turned.

"Don't," Sora rasped.

He stopped.

For once, he obeyed her without surrendering himself.

The room peeled another strip of flesh from her arm. Her blood ran in thin lines toward the heart-suture. The chamber drank greedily, and the passage widened.

Kai's eyes fixed on her hand. "Use what they made."

Sora looked down.

The broken bone had changed. A faint yellow light ran through its center, following the same curve as the mask-key in Kai's hand. It was not the key. It was a splinter of the same mechanism, a piece the room had grown from the connection.

She drew it across the seam.

The cut was small.

The effect was not.

Every mouth in the false Kai's face snapped shut. The room stopped breathing. The caretakers went silent beyond the walls.

Then the echo came apart.

It did not bleed. It unraveled into strips of remembered moments: Kai turning in the corridor, Kai saying her name through the heart-suture, Kai offering himself to the white mask. Each fragment tried to cling to her. Each carried a different expression, a different plea.

Sora cut through them one by one.

The bone burned her palm. Skin lifted from her fingers and drifted away like wet ash. She kept cutting.

"No," the echo whispered.

Sora's arm shook.

"You're not him."

The final strand broke.

The false Kai collapsed inward, folding into a dark knot that the heart-suture swallowed. The one-way window shattered without sound. Cold air struck Sora's face.

For a breath, the passage stood open both ways.

Kai stepped through.

His hand found hers.

The contact was brief, but it was enough. His palm was rough and fever-hot. The mask-key's pulse struck against her wrist, answering the broken bone between them.

"I'm here," Kai said.

Sora's throat closed around a laugh that became a cough. "You're late."

"I got lost."

"You gave away your breath."

"I know."

"And your name."

His eyes flickered toward the wasteland behind him. "Not all of it."

The room began to close.

Threads drew across the opening, pale and wet. The caretakers stirred beyond the walls. Something enormous shifted beneath the floor, turning toward the cold brightness of the passage.

Kai tightened his grip. "Come with me."

Sora looked at the opening. Beyond Kai, the wasteland stretched toward the skeletal arch and the masks waiting under it. Behind her, the flesh room had begun to rebuild itself around her legs. Her skin continued to loosen, peeling in thin translucent layers. She could feel herself becoming less attached to the body she had fought to keep.

She could cross.

She could also tear the passage wider and let the room follow.

"Kai," she said, "if I come through, it may come with me."

"I know."

"Then don't pull."

His face tightened. "Sora - "

"Don't pull."

He understood. That was the thing the false echo had never understood. Kai's love, whatever remained of it after the masks and the sacrifice, had room for her refusal.

He released her hand.

Sora turned the broken bone downward and drove it into the heart-suture.

The room screamed.

The passage slammed shut between them, cutting off Kai's reaching hand. For an instant she saw his fingers on the other side, empty and trembling. Then the membrane sealed over the view.

The flesh room collapsed around Sora.

She fell onto the slick floor as the heart-suture folded into a hard, pale scar. The false echo was gone. The room no longer spoke in Kai's voice.

It spoke in hers.

"Again," it whispered.

Sora stared at the scar.

Her skin slid from her shoulder in a soft sheet. Beneath it, the flesh was pale and numb. She should have been terrified. She was terrified. But beneath the terror lay something steadier than hope.

Choice.

She had not rescued Kai. Not yet. She had not escaped. The room still held her, and the shared passage had closed before she could cross it.

But the scar pulsed once.

From the other side came three knocks.

A pause.

Two.

Sora pressed her bleeding hand against the sealed seam.

This time, the answer traveled both ways.

Separate Nightmares, One Last Choice

Kai felt Sora before he saw the passage.

Her presence moved through the wasteland as a pulse beneath his feet, answering the blood on her hand. The cracked ground shuddered. Mask-faces rolled in the dust and turned their hollow eyes toward him. Somewhere beyond the white glare, something wet and enormous drew breath.

Then the seam opened.

It hung in the air between two ruined places: on one side, Kai's grey-yellow wasteland, its heat and dead wind; on the other, Sora's flesh room, red walls contracting around a corridor of teeth and pale tendons. The threshold was no wider than a doorway. Its edges stitched and unstitched themselves, pale threads sinking into the dust and reappearing in the walls across from them.

Kai stepped toward it.

His body resisted.

The place where the mask-key had entered him burned along his ribs. His breath, already stolen from him, scraped uselessly through a throat that no longer felt entirely human. Each step left a dark outline in the ground. The outline remained after his foot lifted, twitching like a second shadow.

"Sora," he called.

His voice crossed the seam and returned altered, stretched thin through wet tissue.

"Kai."

She stood on the other side.

For one instant she looked as he remembered her. Then the flesh room flexed, and its red light passed over her face. Threads had grown from her wrists. One disappeared beneath her skin. Another ran from her shoulder into the wall, tugging whenever she moved. Her left hand was slick with blood, pressed against the place where she had opened the passage.

Kai wanted only to reach her. To put his hand over hers. To pull her into the wasteland, or step into the flesh room, whichever direction still belonged to them.

The seam narrowed.

Sora saw it too. "Don't rush."

"I'm coming through."

"No." Her voice cracked. "Listen to me."

Behind Kai, the masks began to whisper. His own voice rose from the ground in fragments.

Give him to us.

Open wider.

One nightmare. One shape.

The flesh-creature shifted at the edge of the haze. It had followed him from the center, dragging its many limbs through the dust. Its surface opened and closed

in slow folds. Beneath the folds, faces appeared - not faces exactly, but impressions of mouths and eyes, all trying to remember how to be human.

The flesh room answered with a deep, muscular groan.

Sora's threads tightened. She staggered, and the seam pinched around her arm.

Kai gripped the broken bone at his side and drove its jagged end into the ground. Yellow light shivered through it. The nearest masks recoiled.

"Sora, let go of the wall."

"I can't."

"Then I'll cut you free."

"You cut the false echo. This isn't the same."

The words struck harder than the wind. Kai looked at the living threads entering her skin. They were not restraints alone. They ran through her like roots, carrying the pulse that had brought him here.

The passage had not opened between two places.

It had opened through them.

A shape moved inside Kai's chest. Not the flesh-creature outside him, but the thing it had left behind when it invaded him in the corridor. His ribs flexed. A second rhythm began beneath his own failing pulse.

The seam widened.

For a moment, Kai saw what waited if he crossed completely. Sora's room would fold around him. His wasteland would pour through the opening. Flesh would spread over dust. Masks would bloom from the walls. The two nightmares would not destroy each other. They would combine.

The thought came with terrible gentleness.

No more distance.

Sora's eyes widened. She had seen it in his face.

"Kai," she said. "What is it offering?"

"Us."

The flesh-creature gave a sound like laughter heard underwater.

Sora shook her head. "That isn't us."

The seam pulled at Kai. His feet slid over the cracked ground. Heat vanished from one side of his body while cold, damp pressure closed over the other. His fingers went numb. The outline beneath him climbed his legs, replacing the edges of his skin with pale, uncertain lines.

He reached for Sora.

Their hands met across the threshold.

Her palm was hot and wet. The instant their fingers locked, memories struck him - not images, but sensations. The teeth wall biting into her cherished memory. The false echo wearing his voice. Her hand against the sealed seam. Her fear that the real Kai had become only another thing the room could imitate.

His own memories poured into her in return: the skeletal arch, the masks turning to watch him, the breath he had surrendered, the white mask's narrow split mouth, the moment he had offered himself rather than give her away.

The seam brightened.

Their skin began to change where they touched.

A thin white line spread from Kai's knuckles across Sora's palm. Beneath it, something moved like a thread being pulled through cloth.

Sora gasped. "Let go."

"I can keep it open."

"For how long?"

Kai looked past her. The flesh room had begun to grow toward the doorway. Teeth pushed from the floor. Caretakers emerged from the walls, their hands long and pale, reaching not for Sora but for the space between them.

Behind Kai, the flesh-creature lowered itself and opened its many mouths.

The masks whispered louder.

He understood then. The passage was not a road. It was a demand. It required a single shape to anchor it, a body that belonged to both nightmares. If they merged, the seam would hold. They would survive inside the joining, but neither would remain separate enough to know the other.

Sora stared at him. She understood too.

"No," she said.

Kai tightened his grip. "If we stay apart, it closes."

"And if we join?"

He could not say it.

Her fingers trembled against his. "Say it."

"We won't be us."

The white line on their hands pulsed. His altered breath scraped through his chest. He imagined waking inside the fused nightmare, hearing Sora's thoughts mixed with the masks, feeling her memories grow from his bones. He imagined her face looking back at him with his eyes.

The choice was not between life and death.

It was between losing each other and becoming unable to lose anything.

Sora pulled once, trying to free her hand. The seam tightened around both their wrists.

"Kai, listen." Her voice came through the shared pulse now, close enough to feel inside his skull. "You gave them your identity once."

"I gave them memories."

"You gave them the parts they could use." Her gaze held his. "Don't give them the rest."

The flesh-creature lunged.

Kai saw its limbs cross the wasteland, saw the caretakers surge through the flesh room, saw the seam begin to tear under the pressure. He had one movement left. One choice the passage could not make for him.

He drove the broken bone into the bright line between their hands.

Pain tore through both nightmares.

Sora screamed. Kai felt the sound split his teeth. The bone shattered, scattering faint yellow sparks across the threshold. The white line on their palms snapped.

The seam convulsed.

Kai seized Sora's wrist with his other hand and shoved her backward. The flesh room's threads ripped free of her shoulder. Blood opened in a narrow red track,

but she fell away from the threshold instead of into it.

"Kai!"

He planted himself in the doorway.

The passage seized his altered body. Pale lines spread over his arms and throat. His shadow peeled from the ground and stretched toward Sora, thin as smoke. He caught it with both hands.

It felt like holding cold water.

The flesh-creature struck the seam. Its mouths pressed against the opening, searching for a way through. The masks shrieked behind him. The flesh room bucked beneath Sora, trying to drag her forward.

Kai pulled his shadow back into himself.

Something inside his chest tore loose.

He felt Sora's presence retreat, not vanish but separate, like a hand slipping from his in deep water. The last shared memory between them - the sound of her saying his name through the heart-suture - flared white.

Then Kai forced the seam shut.

The flesh room collapsed away from him. Sora's fingers caught his for half a second.

"Stay alive," she said.

"You too."

The threshold closed between their hands.

Kai fell onto the wasteland floor.

Silence came hard. The masks stopped whispering. The flesh-creature vanished into the haze, cut off from whatever had called it. Around him, the cracked ground sealed into a single dark scar.

On the other side, Sora struck the closing seam with her bleeding palm.

"Kai!"

He tried to answer, but no voice came. His throat had become a smooth, pale channel. He pressed his hand to the place where the passage had been.

A pulse answered.

Not a door. Not a path.

A heartbeat too distant to touch.

The seam finished stitching itself shut. Its pale threads sank into the air until nothing remained but a faint line of yellow light, running across Kai's palm and disappearing beneath his skin.

He looked down.

His hand was still his hand, but the fingers ended in translucent edges. Beneath the skin, small cracks glowed with the same sick light that had filled the broken mask fragment. When he breathed, the light moved.

Across the sealed divide, Sora's room gave one final shudder. Then its red glow receded. The flesh-creatures withdrew. The teeth wall closed over the place where she stood.

Kai remained alone in the wasteland.

The loneliness was not empty. Sora was alive. He could feel that much in the faint answering pulse beneath his palm. But the connection no longer carried words or images. It carried only proof.

He had wanted to reach her.

He had reached her, and chosen to lose the way back.

Kai rose slowly. The broken bone lay at his feet in three pale pieces. He left it there. The masks around him had turned away, their hollow faces aimed toward the distant haze. None of them called him chosen now.

His shadow followed when he moved, though it no longer matched his shape. It dragged a little behind him, thin and torn, bearing the outline of a hand.

Kai started toward the haze.

Far away, through walls of flesh and distance and nightmare, Sora began to walk in the opposite direction.

They were alive.

They were separate.

And whatever they had become, neither nightmare could take the other from them again.

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Separate Nightmares

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